



Hindustan Times

FAB FOURTH AT CWG

Despite several of India's traditionally strong sports being dropped for Glasgow, India did well to finish in the top five in the medals tally. Here's a breakdown on what India gained compared to the previous editions and where it lost out

INDIA'S MEDALS TALLY

13 GOLD

17 SILVER

9 BRONZE

39 TOTAL

RANK 4

A SLEW OF SENSATIONS

MIRABAI CHANU

(Weightlifting)
She dominated the women's 48kg, lifting a Games record total of 190kg for a hat-trick of CWG gold medals, starting in 2016.

GULVEER SINGH

(Athletics)
The 28-year-old Aranyman won the 10,000m silver and 5,000m bronze from a strong field, becoming the first Indian to win two medals in one CWG in athletics.

PREETI PAWAR

(Boxing)
The 54kg boxer, who is only 22, was the pick of India's 7 gold medalists in the ring with sharp footwork and punches.

TEJASWIN SHANKAR

(Decathlon)
He battled to an impressive bronze medal (576) in a strong field, braving the pain of knee tendinitis through the tournament.

YASHVIR SINGH

(Javelin)
He nailed a personal best 85.4m off his final throw to snatch home, just 42cm behind Neeraj Chopra's silver effort.

EYES ON AHMEDABAD 2030

In a 10-sport edition that was heavily downsized, the Indian contingent managed to stand its ground. That also augers well for what's to come at the end of the next four-year cycle - the 2030 CWG in Ahmedabad where India will eye a bigger push on home turf →P13

SPORTS WHERE INDIA GAINED

ATHLETICS

EDITION	1	2	3	4	5
2014 Glasgow	1	1	1	3	
2018 Gold Coast	1	1	1	3	
2022 Birmingham	1	4	3	8	
2026 Glasgow*	3	7	6	16	

* Includes para athletics

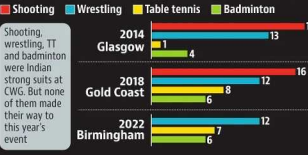
BOXING

EDITION	1	2	3	4	5
2014 Glasgow	0	4	1	5	
2018 Gold Coast	3	3	3	9	
2022 Birmingham	3	1	3	7	
2026 Glasgow	7	3	0	10	

JUDO

EDITION	1	2	3	4	5
2014 Glasgow	0	1	1	4	
2018 Gold Coast	-	-	-	-	
2022 Birmingham	0	2	1	3	
2026 Glasgow*	2	1	1	4	

SPORTS THAT WERE OMITTED



Centre to push 4 bills amid House impasse

Saubhadra Chatterji
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NEW DELHI: The Union government will press ahead with four bills in Parliament on Monday despite continuing protests by the Congress-led Opposition over the alleged Ram Mandir donation theft and its demand for a statement from Union home minister Amit Shah on the violence against students in Delhi. With just nine working days left in the monsoon session, the move signals the government's determination to push key legislation through before the House adjourns on August 13.

Among the business listed for Monday are the passage of a bill to increase the sanctioned strength of Supreme Court judges to 37 and amendments relating to the MSME sector. The government will also introduce legislation to provide a comprehensive statutory framework for the Indian Statistical Institute and a bill to modernise the law governing evidence contained in bankers' books and align it with contemporary digital banking practices.

The government is stepping up its legislative push after securing the passage of two key bills amid Opposition protests last week. In less than 15 minutes, Parliament cleared legislation extending legal protection to Vandana Mataram on par with the National Anthem. On Friday, Parliament also passed legislation tightening provisions relating to delayed registrations

KERALA TOLL RISES TO 8 AMID FRESH SHOWERS; MAJOR TOWNS FLOODED
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Major towns in Kerala and large swathes of rural areas, experienced widespread flooding and waterlogging following incessant heavy rains on Sunday, taking the death toll in rain-related incidents up to eight even as eight others were missing, officials said. Though the intensity of the rains reduced on Sunday, floodwaters did not recede from major urban centres in the state including towns such as Arammula and Ranni, leading to members of the public, MLAs along with NDRF personnel and volunteers joining hands to clear solid waste and remove clogged drains. →P7

Legislative business

BILLS TO BE INTRODUCED

The Indian Statistical Institute Bill, 2026
Provides a comprehensive statutory framework for the Indian Statistical Institute

The Bankers' Books Evidence Bill, 2026
Modernises the law governing evidence in bankers' books for the digital era

BILLS FOR PASSAGE

The Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026
Increases the sanctioned strength of Supreme Court judges to 37

The MSME Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026
Amends the law aimed at facilitating the promotion and development of MSMEs

continued on →P9

SLIPPER HURLED AT MP PAPPU YADAV AT HIS HOUSE OVER PARL SKIT

A man threw a slipper at independent MP Pappu Yadav during a press conference at his Pandara Road house on Sunday after the lawmaker defended his controversial skit at the Parliament House complex on the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple, leading to a scuffle between his supporters and the attacker. Yadav said he would not be intimidated by the "attempt on his life". →P5

2 YRS AFTER OUSTER, HASINA MAY LAY OUT B'DESH RETURN PLAN ON AUGUST 5

Rezaul H Laskar
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NEW DELHI: Former Bangladesh PM Sheikh Hasina is expected to detail her plans to return home at her first virtual interaction with the media on August 5, two years after she fled Dhaka after the fall of her government. →P2

4 OF FAMILY AMONG 5 KILLED AFTER CAR RAMS INTO LORRY

COIMBATORE: Four members of a family were among five killed on Sunday after their speeding car ramed into a stationary water tanker lorry on the Uduimalaipettai-Pollachi National Highway near Coimbatore, police said.
According to officers, the car ramed into the rear of the lorry, which had been halted along the highway's median to water roadside plants. →P6

{ TAIPEI OPEN }

Teen sensation Tanvi Sharma wins 1st BWF World Tour title

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NEW DELHI: Teen badminton sensation Tanvi Sharma announced her arrival on the international stage as she claimed her maiden BWF World Tour title at the \$250,000 Taipei Open on Sunday.

The 17-year-old delivered a masterclass against Vietnamese Nguyen Thuy Linh in the final, beating the sixth seed 21-16, 21-16 in 36 minutes to become the youngest winner across any discipline in the tournament's 46-year history. →P4

This is only the third time an Indian has won the tournament, Saina Nehwal won the women's singles title in 2008, while Jwala Gutta and V Diju claimed the mixed doubles crown a year later.

Despite dropping only one game throughout the week, Sharma was humble at the media interaction.

"I'm really very, very happy to win this title here," the shuttler from Punjab said. "I didn't expect to win a title, but yeah, I just thought I'll give my best over here. I was going step by step, match by match." →P4



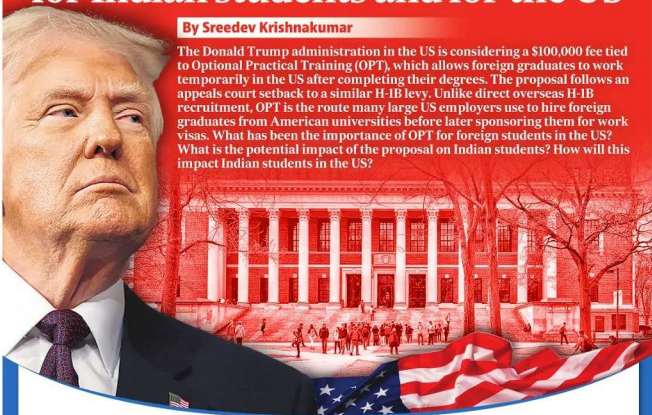
Tanvi Sharma poses with her medal. BADMINTON PHOTO

NUMBER THEORY

\$100k OPT fee plan is bad news for Indian students and for the US

By Sreedev Krishnakumar

The Donald Trump administration in the US is considering a \$100,000 fee tied to Optional Practical Training (OPT), which allows foreign graduates to work temporarily in the US after completing their degrees. The proposal follows an appeals court setback to a similar H-1B levy. Unlike direct overseas H-1B recruitment, OPT is the route many large US employers use to hire foreign graduates from American universities before later sponsoring them for work visas. What has been the importance of OPT for foreign students in the US? What is the potential impact of the proposal on Indian students? How will this impact Indian students in the US?

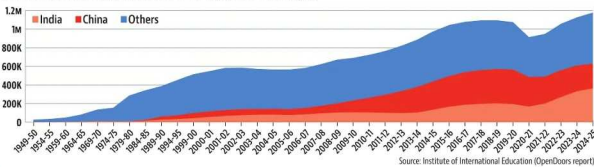


1 India is now the biggest source of foreign students in the US

For more than a decade, China was the largest source of international students in the US. Both Indian and Chinese numbers fell in 2020-21, but their recoveries soon diverged. India's count rose from 167,582 that year to 363,019 in 2024-25, more than doubling in four years. China's, by contrast, recovered

only briefly before sliding from 317,299 to 265,919. Indians now make up roughly 31% of all international students in the US, compared with 23% for China. Indians are now the biggest beneficiaries of H-1B visas and, as international students in the US, biggest potential beneficiaries of the OPT route to employment.

International students in the US by place of origin

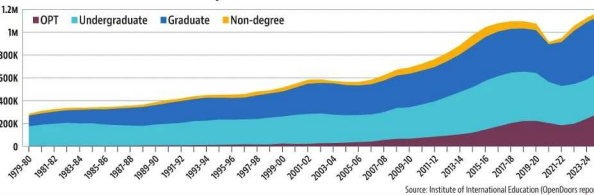


2 Enrolments by foreign students in American universities had already begun to lose steam

America's international student total was still rising in 2024-25, but the growth was increasingly coming from people who had already left the classroom. The combined number of undergraduate, graduate and non-degree students fell marginally from the previous year, while graduate enrolment alone declined by nearly 14,000. The headline total nevertheless increased by more than 51,000 because the number of students on OPT rose from 242,782 to 294,253. OPT participants, mostly recent graduates temporarily permitted to work in jobs related to their degrees, consequently accounted for one-quarter of the international student count, up from less than 19% two years earlier and about 12% a decade ago. America's

foreign student population was, in other words, being sustained increasingly by yesterday's students rather than new enrolments. The intake pipeline appears to have weakened further since then. The Global Enrolment Benchmarking study, produced by NAFSA, Oxford Test of English and Studyportals, found that new international enrolments at 149 participating US universities during January to March 2026 fell by an average 20% at bachelor's level and 24% at master's level from the same intake a year earlier. Around 62% of the US institutions reported lower enrolment at both levels. The survey is not a national headcount and participating universities were self-selected, but it is indicative of the broader trend.

International students in the US by academic level

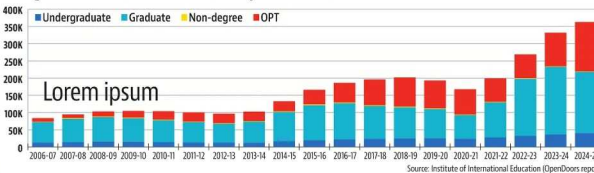


3 Rise in Indian students in recent years led to boom in graduate workers who will be disproportionately hit by the proposal

The proposed fee would not fall evenly across America's international student population. Indians accounted for 143,740 of the 294,253 people on OPT in 2024-25, or nearly 49%. That makes India unusually exposed to any attempt to put a six-figure price on the bridge between a US degree and a US job. In fact, India's enrolment surge had already begun to fade beneath the headline numbers. While the total number of Indian students in the US rose by 31,417 in 2024-25, the number actually enrolled in undergraduate, graduate or non-degree

programmes fell by 14,767. Graduate enrolment dropped by almost 19,000, while the OPT population jumped by more than 46,000. In other words, the entire increase in Indian student population came from recent graduates staying on to work through OPT. A \$100,000 levy would weaken the calculation made by future applicants, especially those pursuing costly graduate degrees on the expectation that US earnings will help justify the investment. To be sure, the proposal remains under discussion, including who would ultimately bear the cost.

Foreign students in the US from India by academic level



4 America risks pricing away its advantage

Who writes the cheque remains unclear. The administration has not said whether the \$100,000 fee would be paid by students, employers or universities. But the burden would be hard to contain. Students could face higher costs and fewer job offers, employers could become choosier, and universities could find an

already weakening recruitment market even harder to sell. The US has been the world's leading destination for international students. Yet its advantage rests partly on what follows the degree. Make that bridge prohibitively expensive, and America risks undermining one of its biggest attractions for global talent.



Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Trump pauses strikes, claims deal emerging

Reuters

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CAIRO: President Donald Trump has said the U.S. will hold off on a fresh attack on Iran as long as a deal can be reached quickly to halt Iran's nuclear ambitions and reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump said late on Saturday on his Truth Social platform that Iran and other Middle Eastern countries had asked for time to complete a deal that would lead to "the immediate, complete and total" reopening of the vital Strait and "an end to Iran's nuclear threat".

He did not name the countries in the post, which followed a call with Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman of Saudi Arabia, a U.S. ally.

"Based on this request, I have agreed, for the future benefit of the WORLD and, likewise, the survival of a successful and prosperous Iran, to cancel the attack, subject to being able to rapidly make a DEAL," Trump wrote.

Israel "joins me in this commitment," he said. Iran's official news agency IRNA reported on Sunday that negotiations between Tehran and Oman over the Strait of Hormuz were in their final stages, citing Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi. Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said negotiations were focused on agreeing a new route through the Strait, adding that it had "no link to the Strait of Hormuz being opened or closed. That is a separate discussion".

Fresh hope for West Asia peace

Trump speaks to MBS

Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman told US President Donald Trump in a call that he was concerned over the U.S. plans for new strikes against Iran, said officials. He urged Trump to refrain from new strikes and "asked for clarity about the plan of action".

'Parameters of deal to end war reached'

Trump said he will order US forces to hold off on new strikes against Iran, claiming allies in the region have reached the parameters of a deal to end the war.



Pak-backed MoU to be revived?

An Iranian lawmaker Hassan Ghasseini said mediators were trying to revive the memorandum of understanding agreed in June.

Iran, Oman close to Hormuz deal

Iran's foreign ministry said Tehran and Muscat were close to reaching a deal on a new maritime route through the Strait of Hormuz, separate from the existing corridors. Details of the new route were not immediately clear.

Iran: No return to pre-war status

Iran's foreign ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said on Sunday that the Strait of Hormuz "will in no way return to the status it was before February 28th," the day the war started.

Last month Iran publicly rejected an Omani proposal, backed by Gulf states, to manage the Strait they share. People familiar with the matter had told Reuters the plan included the collection of voluntary fees for using the Strait.

Trump's apparent de-escalation after days of threats of new attacks from each side was the latest twist in the war the U.S. and Israel launched five months ago. Attacks have spread across the Gulf to the Red Sea and even a Mediterranean facility in Egypt. Iran has largely closed the Strait of Hormuz, a conduit for 20% of the world's oil and liquefied natural gas before the

continued on 99

IRAN'S LEADERS SHOW UNITED FRONT ON WAR BUT DIVIDED ON GOALS

Amid escalating attacks against US and its allies, Iran's leaders are showing considerable unity over their war strategy: hanging tough, determined to show Iran can endure more than US and its allies can. But within the leadership, there are sharp differences over what the endgame should be. On one side, the ultra-hardliners who oppose any negotiations with the US are pressing for total victory in the war. On the other, those who support President Masoud Peshkian, parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf see military pressure as a way to win a negotiated deal with the US.

OPEC+ AGREES SEPT QUOTA HIKE TO FINISH UNWINDING 2023 CUTS

OPEC+ approved an oil production quota increase on Sunday of around 185,000 barrels per day from September, the producer group said, in a move that completes the unwinding of a layer of voluntary output cuts. Due to export disruptions from the Gulf, Russia and Kazakhstan caused by the Iran and Ukraine wars, successive monthly OPEC+ hikes over most of this year have remained largely on paper with little impact on the market. The increase agreed by OPEC+ members finishes the phased rollback of a 165 million bpd supply cut originally agreed in 2023.

REUTERS

TAKE PLEDGE AGAINST DRUG ABUSE, MODI URGES YOUTH

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday asked the country's youth to take a pledge against substance abuse, saying drugs can give them a "high" for some time, but would make their entire career and personal life "low".

Launching the 'Nasha Mukti Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan', Modi said: You will shape your lives over the next 20-25 years, and you will lead the country to the goal of a Viksit Bharat in 2047, and you will be at the helm... The country needs your energy, your imagination, and your talent, so staying drug-free is crucial for the country and for your own lives.



VERIFY, DEMARCAT WETLANDS IN TWO MTHS: SC TO GOVTS

Utarkash Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has tightened its oversight over the protection of India's wetlands, directing the Centre, states and UTs to physically verify and demarcate all wetlands identified in the Space Applications Centre (SAC) Atlas within two months, while warning that secretaries and other senior officials will be summoned to court if the exercise remains confined to paperwork.

The latest order marks a significant escalation by the top court in a litigation it has been monitoring since 2018 to ensure identification, notification and protection of wetlands across the country.

Only one active local terrorist left in J&K

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NEW DELHI: Jammu & Kashmir now has just one active local terrorist left, according to records maintained by security agencies including the police and Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), with officers mounting an intensive hunt for Kulgam resident Mohammed Lateef Bhat, whom investigators suspect was behind the killing of two migrant workers from Chhattisgarh, the July 22 shooting of a head constable and plans to target the ongoing Amarnath Yatra, said people aware of the matter.

People familiar with the matter said updated security records show there is now only



Mohammed Lateef Bhat

one active local terrorist in Jammu and Kashmir, compared with 40-50 foreign terrorists operating across the Union territory, said a security officer.

Around five years ago, security agencies estimated there were 50-60 active local terrorists. As recently as May 2025, official records showed 17

active local terrorists - 14 in Kashmir and three in Jammu - along with around 60 foreign terrorists said the official cited above.

The fall in local recruitment is due to the crackdown by security forces on one hand and National Investigation Agency (NIA) probes over the past few years that have throttled groups that were allegedly funding terrorism. In the last two years, a massive crackdown on terror financing and narco terrorism was launched by the NIA.

According to security officials, Bhat escaped during a joint operation by the Army, Jammu and Kashmir Police and the CRPF in which security

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{ KANWAR YATRA NOISE }

All rules thrown to the wind, Delhi loses sleep

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: Noise pollution, choked roads, and traffic diversions marked the start of the annual Kanwar Yatra in the Capital, which serves as a thoroughfare on their way to and back from the Ganges. Residents complained of late-night processions blaring music through boom boxes well beyond permissible limits, rattling homes and setting off health risks, alleging little police intervention despite the blatant violation of a raft of norms.

Among the worst affected are

U'KHAND: OVERSIZED KANWARS SENT BACK

Kanwars (bamboo poles with water containers) exceeding the permitted height of 15 feet were being returned by the Uttarakhand police at various entry points along the Uttar Pradesh border during the ongoing Shrawan Kanwar Mela, officers said.

CAUVERY DISPUTE: VIJAY DEFERRED B'LURU VISIT ON MY REQUEST, SAYS DKS

Arun Dev and S Vijay Karthik

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BENGALURU/CHENNAI: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar on Sunday said Shrikanth Nadu counterpart C Joseph Vijay agreed to postpone his planned Bengaluru visit at his request, arguing that the decision would help preserve a peaceful atmosphere amid the Cauvery water dispute.

Meanwhile, Tamil Nadu minister R Nirmal Kumar said that the state has decided to approach the Supreme Court for an "immediate solution" to the long-standing issue.

KRACKJACK JOKE #3

IS JACK RICH OR BROKE?

SCAN TO KNOW MORE

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*Individual Death Claims Paid Ratio as per Annual Audited Financials for FY 2025-26. Claims Paid Ratio rounded off to the nearest single decimal figure. 1. The "3 Click Claim Process" refers to the three primary CTAs in the digital claims journey. Additional verification, documentation, or other steps may be required depending on the claim.

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- RDN or its officials do not involve in activities like selling insurance policies, announcing bonus or investments of premiums
- Public receiving such phone calls are requested to lodge a police complaint

IRDAI Regn. No. 104

{ WORLD } 'IN-FLIGHT EMERGENCY'

13 killed after tourist plane crashes in Peru

A small plane carrying foreign tourists to view Peru's famed Nazca Lines archaeological site crashed Saturday, killing all 13 people on board, police said. Seven Italian, two German and two Spaniards were killed, along with two crew members, a spokesman for the transport ministry said, adding that the victims were aged between 24 and 78. The incident occurred shortly after 10.00pm local time after the Cessna 208 Caravan aircraft took off from the airport in Pisco, located about 240 kilometers south of the capital Lima. "We have information that 11 passengers and two crew members have died," Police Major Jorge Andrade said. "Given the severity of the accident, there are no survivors," Andrade said. Municipal officials in Vista Alegre, where the plane crashed, said in a statement that preliminary information indicated an "in-flight emergency" was to blame, without offering more details. **APF**

Hasina may outline Bangladesh return plans on August 5

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NEW DELHI: Former Bangladesh prime minister Sheikh Hasina is expected to detail her plans to return home at her first virtual interaction with the media in New Delhi on Wednesday, exactly two years after she fled Dhaka following the fall of her government.

Hasina has lived in self-exile in India since she left Bangladesh in August 5, 2024, when the Awami League regime dramatically collapsed in the face of mass student-led protests. Her plans to virtually address the media are unlikely to go down well with the Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) government, which has sought her extradition. The deposed 78-year-old is set to address the virtual news conference at the Foreign Correspondents' Club in Delhi.

The event will also feature an address by Hasina's son Sajed Wazed Joy, and other Awami League leaders such as former education minister Hasan Chowdhury, Novif and former cricketer and MP Shabbir Al Hasan. Muhammad Ali Siddique, general secretary of Bangladesh Human Rights Watch, Shah Mohammad Bahadur, director of Bangladesh Human Rights Watch USA, security analyst Aminul Hoque Polash, and counter-terrorism analyst Abu Obaidha Arin are also expected to join the event. Some of them will participate in person and others will appear virtually.

While Hasina has given several email interviews and virtually addressed online events — including meetings organised by

THE DEPOSED 78-YEAR-OLD IS SET TO ADDRESS THE VIRTUAL NEWS CONFERENCE AT THE FOREIGN CORRESPONDENTS' CLUB IN DELHI

the Awami League and a news conference at the Foreign Correspondents' Club this January — this is the first time she is expected to participate in a question-and-answer session.

Hasina, who has been sentenced to death by a tribunal in Dhaka for ordering the use of lethal force in the crackdown on student protesters, has said in recent interviews that she intends to go back to Bangladesh by December and surrender to the courts. Bangladesh's law minister M Asaduzzaman said last week she is likely to be immediately arrested if she returns from India.

Hasina's presence in India remains a key irritant in relations with the Bangladesh government, which has barred the local media from publishing or broadcasting the former PM's interviews. Although the activities of the Awami League continue to be banned under an anti-terrorism law, several party leaders have signalled their intention to return to Bangladesh this year as part of efforts to revive the party.

Hasina told HT in May that her return is linked to a "democratic environment in Bangladesh, freedom of expression, political rights and the restoration of the rule of law," which is also necessary for "protecting the country's independence and sovereignty and ensuring the overall welfare of the people".

{ AN AGATHA CHRISTIE MASTERPIECE }

Mystery, mastery and a tumultuous twist: Roger Ackroyd at 100

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The contents page should have been the first clue: the last chapter is titled "Apologia". What could the author possibly have to apologise for?

It's been a hundred years since Agatha Christie wrote *The Murder of Roger Ackroyd* — her sixth novel, but arguably the most popular one — and for the world, that's a century of readers being led by the nose and sold down the river.

Roger Ackroyd, we are told in the second chapter of the book, is "more impossible like a country square than a country squire could be". Telling us this is a stand-in for James Sheppard, the narrator.

As first-person narrators go, Sheppard is rather judgmental. He disparages his sister, Catherine's respectable network of informants from whom she gets to hear of all the goings on in the village. He refuses to acknowledge her observations though he may agree with many of them. He pokes fun at

Ackroyd, who, it turns out, is "an immensely successful manufacturer" and the "life and soul of King Abbott", the quiet English village in which the novel is set.

"Apologia" is a bit curmudgeonly, but we don't grudge him that. He is a doctor and what's more, he is the one telling us the story — so we owe him with his point of view.

A murder is announced
The book begins with a death, and Sheppard has to decide whether to recommend an inquest or not; his position of power and trustworthiness is well-established.

As the narrative progresses, Christie leaves clues all over the place. A crucial meeting with Ackroyd, Sheppard returns home and to avoid his sister's queries, makes up "a slightly fictitious account of the evening" to "satisfy her curiosity".

He writes about meeting with Ackroyd shortly before the man's death, but leaves out what happens during a crucial 10-minute period. As readers,



Agatha Christie

we are used to this: after all, no novel offers a blow-by-blow account of every single minute of the protagonists' lives. Time shifts are expected. Here lay Christie's genius. She played with the norms of the written text and subverted our expectations.

Later in the book, Sheppard even receives a ringing endorsement from none other than Hercule Poirot himself. Handling over the manuscript he has maintained of the events to Poirot, Sheppard is delighted when the Belgian detective praises him.

"A very meticulous and accurate account," you have recorded

{ WORLD } FIVE COPS AMONG DEAD

Suicide attack during protest in northwestern Pak kills 14



A suicide bomber targeted protesters at an antiterrorist rally in northwestern Pakistan on Sunday, killing at least 14 people, mostly civilians and police officers, and wounding more than two dozen others, officials said. The attack happened in Kabi, a town in Swat Valley in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, where demonstrators had gathered near a police station, chanting anti-militant slogans and demanding peace, district police chief Omar Khan said. Bilal Faizi, a spokesman for the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa provincial emergency service, said the attacker struck dozens of people who were chanting antiterrorist slogans and demanding peace. Khan said at least nine civilians and five officers were among the dead. Pakistan's President Asif Ali Zardari and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif condemned the bombing, expressing deep sorrow over the loss of life. Zardari and Sharif also said Pakistan's fight against terrorism would continue until it is eradicated. **AP**

{ WORLD } TERROR ATTACK

Female bomber kills 3, injures 21 in Moscow



A homemade bomb carried by a woman killed at least three people and injured 21 near an upscale restaurant in central Moscow on Saturday evening, authorities said, amid unconfirmed speculation on social media that the attack may have been linked to the war in Ukraine. The explosion occurred just before 8pm close to an Italian restaurant located in one of Moscow's seven Stalin-era skyscrapers at Kudrinskaya Square, the police said. NAK said the woman, the guard and a customer at the Balzi Rossi Italian restaurant had been killed instantly in the blast that followed. Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin on Sunday offered his condolences to the families of those killed and said those responsible would be punished. "A brutal terrorist attack was carried out in Moscow yesterday," he said in a statement. **REUTERS**

{ WORLD } GREECE TRAGEDY

2 die as firefighting helicopters collide



Two Greek firefighting helicopters collided in midair on Sunday as they were battling a wind-driven wildfire west of Athens, sending one aircraft crashing to the ground. Two crew members, a Greek and a Danish national, died in the crash. The collision laid bare the danger at the most volatile front of Europe's wildfire emergency. Strong winds drove flames deeper into the region of the Greek capital and forced fresh evacuations. France guarded a still-burning scar four times the size of Paris, while Spain's major fires stopped advancing. The aircraft were Bell helicopters operating over the Pitha area west of Athens, each with a two-person crew. Greek Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis expressed "sorrow for the tragic accident" and extended condolences to the families of the deceased. Foreign firefighting crews are often deployed in Greece to help tackle wildfires during the country summers. **AP**

FINDING A WAY AROUND HORMUZ

Disruption to shipping through the Strait of Hormuz has prompted oil-producing countries in the Gulf to accelerate plans for alternative export routes, with a series of pipeline projects announced or revived. Here is a breakdown of the proposals

CRUDE OIL PIPELINES BYPASSING HORMUZ

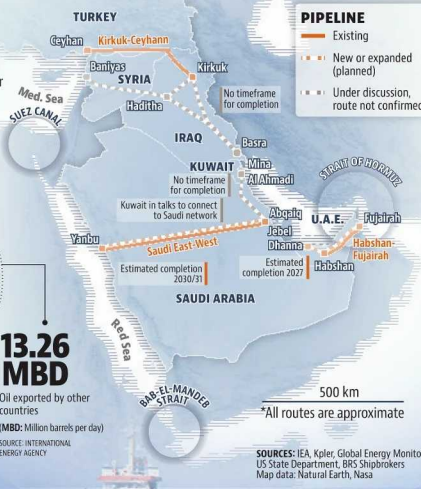
Existing and planned pipelines provide alternative long-term export routes for Gulf crude

CRUDE OIL EXPORTED THROUGH THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ IN 2025



(MBO: Million barrels per day)

SOURCE: INTERNATIONAL ENERGY AGENCY



SAUDI ARABIA

THE PIPELINE: Before the war broke out in late February, Saudi Arabia transported around 2mbd of crude through its East-West Pipeline linking Abqaiq, near the Red Sea, with the Red Sea port of Yanbu, according to the IEA. State oil giant Aramco said in March 2023 it had increased the pipeline's capacity to 7mbd, leaving up to 5mbd of spare capacity.

THE EXPANSION PLAN: Riyadh is also planning a further expansion of up to 2 mbd, according to the Institute for Energy Research (IER). The project could be completed by 2030-31.

UNITED ARAB EMIRATES

THE PIPELINE: Before the conflict, the UAE exported around 1.1mbd of crude through its Abu Dhabi Crude Oil Pipeline, which links inland oil fields with the port of Fujairah on the Gulf of Oman, bypassing the Strait of Hormuz. IEA said the pipeline had a capacity of 1.8 mbd, leaving an additional 0.7 mbd available.

THE EXPANSION: The UAE said in May it was fast-tracking construction of a second pipeline that would run parallel to the existing route before extending to the country's northern coast. The project will double export capacity through Fujairah and is likely to enter service next year, said the Abu Dhabi Media Office.

IRAQ

THE PIPELINE AND THE EXPANSION: The US has said plans are underway to restore a major pipeline linking Iraq's oil fields with Syria's Mediterranean coast. Washington is overseeing an international consortium "to assess the technical and financial aspects of this project", which is expected to have an initial capacity of 2 mbd, the department said. No timetable has been announced, however, and political and investment hurdles risk delaying the project, experts warned.

all the facts faithfully and exactly — though you have shown yourself becoming reticent as to your own share in them," Poirot told Sheppard.

The last phrase is the biggest clue in the novel, and it was before: purists were outraged, devotees were impressed. Dorothy L Sayers, a detective fiction writer and Christie's friend, even defended the story's ending, stating that it was the reader's job to suspect everybody.

Cards on the table
It is rare for a book to remain relevant a hundred years after it was written, and *Roger Ackroyd* certainly qualifies as one of them. Only a few things date the book, such as a reference to a "scientific machine" that "registers finger heartbeats" (a lie detector), and the vital role

of the "dictaphone" (a voice recording machine) in mystery, but the storytelling as well as the reactions of all characters is true to form: in this, Christie remains a masterful writer.

The Murder of Roger Ackroyd was the first of Christie's stories to be adapted into a play. Titled *Alibi*, it opened at the Prince of Wales Theatre in London's West End in May 1928. John Moffat, one of the most popular actors to perform the role of Hercule Poirot on radio adaptations of Christie's novels began with Roger Ackroyd in 1987 — the first time it aired on the BBC Radio 4 was in December.

There have also been countless adaptations of the book all over the globe — from Japan to South Africa. In India too, the book has been translated into multiple languages.

But Christie's novel was significant also for the literature it came to be part of. The novel came out the same year Franz Kafka's *The Castle* was posthumously released. In the, protagonist K goes through many futile attempts to reach the

authority governing his village council. William Faulkner's *Soldier's Pay* was another novel to be released that year, which followed a group of World War I veterans and their disillusionment.

Ernest Hemingway's *The Sun Also Rises* and the English translation of Andre Gide's *The Counterfeiters*, also published that year, told their stories in a similar style that broke away from the staid 19th century third-person narrative, and instead offered fragmented perspectives, unreliable narrators and questionable authority figures.

Four years later, another detective novel, *The Maltese Falcon*, written by Samuel D. Hammett across the Atlantic, brought about yet another shape-shifting change to the genre: he turned it into an urban thriller. This was not a fluke. Modernism, the broad current under which these works fell, was marked by such experimentation with both form and content.

Cat among the pigeons
TS Eliot, whose fame as a poet was only superseded by his as a literary critic, articulated many

of the standards for detective fiction in *The Criterion* (a literary journal he published) in 1927. A key tenet was fair play — the reader should have a fair shot at solving the crime — and there should be no surprises as to the occur or other such sleight-of-hand solutions.

Ronald A. Knox, a Catholic priest who ran the London Detection Club (which counted among its members Sayers, Christie and G. Chesterton), also wrote the Ten Commandments of detective fiction echoing many of Eliot's pronouncements about the genre. "Roger Ackroyd" pushed the boundaries of what detective fiction could do.

Yet, not everyone was convinced of its value when it was first published. *The New Yorker* reviewer Edmund Wilson wrote a piece titled, "Who Cares Who Killed Roger Ackroyd?" in 1945, in which he famously ranked detective stories as a kind of vice that lay somewhere between crosswords and smoking. He also called them "wasteful of time" and "degrading to the intelligence". In a previous piece titled, "Why Do People Read Detective Stories?" published a year before, he tried to

explain the hold that such literature, poor though it was, had over our collective imagination. "The detective story has kept its hold; had even, in the two decades between the great wars, become more popular than ever before; and there is, I believe, a deep reason for this. The world during those years was ridden by an all-pervasive feeling of guilt and by a fear of impending disaster which it seemed hopeless to try to avert, because it never seemed convincingly possible to pin down the responsibility," he wrote. "Nobody seems guiltless, nobody seems safe; and then, suddenly, the murderer is spotted, and—relief!—he is not, after all, a person like you or me. He is a villain!" he added.

Curtains
Wilson wasn't off the mark. Cultural theorists today agree that the function of murder mysteries and detective stories help the reader find order in chaos. The figure of the detective upheld the moral order; he brought things to right when they'd gone awry. Roger Ackroyd cemented Hercule Poirot's unshakable position in the pantheon.

Cauvery water release to TN regions, CM meets all-party meet

Arun Dev
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BENGALURU: Karnataka began releasing Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu under the river authority's latest directive, even as the state's political leadership closed ranks on Sunday, backing a common legal strategy while arguing that swollen reservoirs left little choice but to allow excess water to flow downstream, leaders in the know said.



CM DK Shivakumar with party leaders at a meeting on Cauvery water issue, in Bengaluru on Sunday.

the language of others," he said. With farmer organisations and Kannada groups calling for a statewide bandh on August 13, Shivakumar appealed for the protest to be withdrawn, saying the government was already pursuing every legal and political option available. "I will speak to farmers, Kannada organisations and opposition leaders. Our ministers will also speak. When the government is standing with you and nature is also with you, bandh is of no use. It will affect our schools and business. Ultimately, it will not help us. We are committed to farmers' welfare and bound to protect state interest," he said.

The all-party meeting sought to project unity at a time when the dispute has entered another legal phase. Leaders from the Congress, BJP and JD(S), including six former chief ministers headed by the Opposition R Ashok, attended the meeting. The BJP joined the discussions after initially considering a boycott while demanding that Karnataka and other states all releases to Tamil Nadu.

Addressing the gathering, Shivakumar urged political parties to place the state's interests above partisan divisions. "The interests of the state's farmers and people are above politics. Karnataka's priority is to resolve the river sharing issue through dialogue. Adequate water has been stored to ensure that there is no shortage of drinking water."

The natural flow of water is

being released since the Kabinri reservoir has reached full capacity. Water has already been released into canals, benefitting farmers across the region," he said.

Recalling Karnataka's handling of earlier phases of the dispute, he added: "We have all grown up witnessing the Cauvery dispute. Karnataka has a tradition of all political parties setting aside differences and standing united to protect the state's interests. Our stand has always been that drinking water must receive the highest priority." Shivakumar said the government was closely watching the DMK's petition before the Supreme Court while preparing for what could become a prolonged legal process. "We are closely watching the situation. We have to utilise our experience," he said.

He said the Cauvery Water Management Authority could continue reviewing the situation every fortnight until January 2027, requiring Karnataka to remain prepared with its legal team. The chief minister also said he had met Union ministers CR Patil, Prahalad Joshi and V Somaiya, before the CWC and CWMA meeting to present Karnataka's concerns before the Centre.

The state's concerns were raised before the meeting. During the meeting of Members of Parliament, leaders across party lines had set aside political differences and pledged to stand united," he said. The Cauvery dispute is a long-running issue, but the conflict between Karnataka and Tamil Nadu, with both states contesting allocations from the river, especially in deficit years. The issue resurfaced amid

CM Vijay agreed to postpone B'uru visit on my request: DKS

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BENGALURU/CHENNAI: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar said Sunday that Tamil Nadu CM K. Joseph Vijay agreed to postpone his visit to Bengaluru after Karnataka requested him to do so to maintain a peaceful atmosphere amid the Cauvery water-sharing dispute, even as Tamil Nadu stated it would instead move the Supreme Court over the issue as an immediate solution.

Speaking after an all-party meeting over the Cauvery issue, Shivakumar said he had personally urged Vijay to delay the visit because public sentiment in Karnataka was running high. "I have great respect for him. Though he may be new to politics, he is a courageous leader. Whatever our political differences may be, he wanted to come to Karnataka. I only requested that we meet in a better and more cordial atmosphere because I don't want anyone shouting against my friends. We should respect each other. We have to live together and work together. Ultimately, India is one," Shivakumar said. Meanwhile, Tamil Nadu minister for natural resources, Arjun Kumar, said Vijay's proposed visit to Bengaluru, said, "CM Vijay consulted various parties and decided that the government must file a case immediately in the Supreme Court."

"After filing of the case, the CM will certainly engage in efforts for friendly relations," Kumar said, indicating that Vijay would take up the visit later. The Cauvery dispute is a long-running issue, but the conflict between Karnataka and Tamil Nadu, with both states contesting allocations from the river, especially in deficit years. The issue resurfaced amid

THE NATURAL RESOURCES MINISTER SAID VIJAY CONSULTED VARIOUS PARTIES AND DECIDED THAT THE GOVERNMENT MUST FILE A CASE IN SUPREME COURT

developments concerning the Mekedatu balancing reservoir project, proposed by Karnataka, a major point of friction between the two states, with Tamil Nadu traditionally opposing it because it would affect the flow of water downstream.

Shivakumar also defended Karnataka's compliance with the Cauvery Water Management Authority's order to release 3,500 cusecs of water to Tamil Nadu for 15 days, saying the state was honouring the order despite the difficulties created by deficient rainfall. "We are closely watching the situation. We respect the sentiments of the people and the law of the country. As per the orders passed, we are releasing water, and I hope there will be no problem," he said.

He again described the proposed Mekedatu balancing reservoir as the long-term answer to the Cauvery dispute, arguing that Tamil Nadu would receive most of its advantages. "If the Mekedatu reservoir is built, nearly 90 per cent of the benefit will go to Tamil Nadu, more than Karnataka. At no point can that water be diverted back to Bengaluru. Anyone who visits the project site and understand the facts," he said.

Kumar, when asked about the DMK's decision to postpone the visit to Bengaluru, said the government must file a case immediately in the Supreme Court over the issue, alleging that the DMK family and Shivakumar have been in a "very good relationship" and it goes beyond party lines.

Cabinet expansion awaits Ceng top brass' approval

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BENGALURU: The Congress leadership has yet to give formal approval to Karnataka's expanded ministry, leaving the state's Cabinet composition unresolved even as preparations continue for a oath-taking ceremony that party leaders hope to hold after the final list reaches Bengaluru, leaders in the know said on Sunday.

Chief minister D K Shivakumar has submitted a proposed list of 20 legislators to the Congress leadership following several rounds of discussions in Bengaluru, they said, adding that another round of consultations is expected before the names receive final clearance.

The party has informed Shivakumar that the approved list is likely to be communicated by Monday.

If that happens, the swearing-in ceremony is expected to take place later in the day at Lok Bhavan, where arrangements have already begun. However, government officials have not

CM SUBMITTED A PROPOSED LIST OF 20 LEGISLATORS TO THE LEADERSHIP AFTER ROUNDS OF DISCUSSIONS IN NEW DELHI, OFFICIALS SAID

announced the official schedule. Home minister Priyank Kharge indicated that the exercise was nearing completion after returning from Delhi.

"The state cabinet will be expanded tomorrow (Monday). A new cabinet will be formed tomorrow (Monday) with new ministers," he said. Shivakumar also expressed confidence that the ministry would soon be expanded but declined to commit to a schedule. "The cabinet expansion is certain. But the specific date will be announced at the appropriate time," he said.

The prolonged exercise has left Karnataka's two-month-old government functioning with

20 vacancies in its 34-member Council of Ministers ahead of the legislature's August 13 session. Congress leaders have been working to settle competing claims from more than 40 aspirants seeking ministerial positions.

Leaders in the know said the high command is assessing candidates on seniority, loyalty to the party and organisational considerations while also weighing broader representation.

The leadership is also considering giving greater representation to women and is expected to decide on additional deputy chief minister positions as part of the exercise.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi are expected to examine the proposed names after receiving inputs from AICC general secretaries K C Venugopal and R R Surjewala.

Venugopal, who had been expected to arrive in Bengaluru with the approved list, did not travel after the decision was deferred.

Heavy rain eases water woes, but hits trains, leaves 3 dead

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BENGALURU: Heavy rainfall in Karnataka led to a rise in inflows into the Cauvery basin reservoirs, easing concerns over water scarcity. It also led to three deaths and many injuries as landslides hit roads and rail traffic was affected in Malnad region, authorities said on Sunday.

Three members of a family, including a three-year-old child, were killed in a train-triggered landslide in Shivamogga district.

Police said Mallikarjun (35), his wife Nagaveni (28) and their 3-year-old son, were killed in a train-triggered landslide in Shivamogga district. Police said Mallikarjun (35), his wife Nagaveni (28) and their 3-year-old son, were killed in a train-triggered landslide in Shivamogga district.

A person staying in a neighbouring shed also sustained serious injuries and was admitted to a private hospital.

Fire and Emergency Services personnel and police carried out rescue operations to retrieve the bodies from the debris.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) said extremely heavy rainfall continued over parts of the Malnad and coastal regions, with Agumbe in Shivamogga district recording 137 mm during the 24 hours ending 5:30 am on Sunday, followed by Ghatprabha in Shivamogga district recording 137 mm, Brahmanur in Udupi (60 mm), Balehonur in Chikmagalur (58 mm) and Sirsi in Uttara Kannada (52.5 mm).

Mangaluru recorded 37.8 mm at the airport, while Bengaluru registered only trace rainfall at its observatories. Heavy rain also triggered a



Rescue operation underway following a landslide in Gandhi Nagar at Theerthahalli town, in Shivamogga on Sunday.

landslide between Edakuratti and Shirahalli railway stations in Hassan district's Sakleshpur taluk, damaging tracks and forcing the suspension of seven train services. In the Malnad region, with Mangaluru, Sirsi, Kozhikode, Murudeshwar and Vijayapura.

Railway authorities advised passengers to make alternative travel arrangements after mud and boulders fell on the tracks. The disruption also affected candidates travelling for the Civil Police Constable examination, officials said.

Meanwhile, continuous rainfall in Kerala and the Cauvery catchment areas, significantly improved water storage in Karnataka's reservoirs.

Officials said inflows into the Kabinri reservoir at Beechanahalli in Mysuru district rose to about 30,000 cusecs, while outflows increased to around 25,000 cusecs as the reservoir level reached about 82 feet against its full reservoir level of 84 feet.

The increased discharge submerged the low-level Bidarahalli bridge in Saragur taluk, prompting

authorities to warn people living along the Kabinri river to move to safer places.

The Krishnaraja Sagar (KRS) reservoir in Mandya district also registered a sharp rise in the water level, increasing from about 92 feet to 97 feet within two days and storing rising from around 17 TMC to 20.47 TMC, according to officials.

The improved inflows have eased concerns over water availability amid the ongoing Cauvery water-sharing dispute and reduced fears that reservoirs were nearing dead storage levels.

The IMD on Sunday also issued a three-hour nowcast warning of a sharp rise in rainfall over parts of the Western Ghats, forecasting moderate rain with intense spells accompanied by sustained winds of 40-50 kmph at isolated places.

It warned of temporary power disruptions, minor traffic snarls, damage to weak trees, kutcha structures and harvested crops, and advised people to remain indoors, avoid travel where possible, stay away from waterbodies and unplugged electrical appliances.

Govt dismisses claims of 7,000 HIV-positive students as misleading

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BENGALURU: The state government on Sunday dismissed widely circulated claims that 7,000 students in Karnataka were HIV positive for HIV during an ongoing awareness campaign, calling the figures false and urging the media to correct the report, officials said. The campaign, aimed at expanding testing and reducing stigma across Karnataka's colleges, has become the target of misinformation, officials added.

The Karnataka State AIDS Prevention Society (KSAPS), under the department of health and family welfare, said the reports were "completely false and misleading" and appealed to media organisations to publish its clarification to prevent public chaos.

The rebuttal came as the state rolled out the eight-month Mobilisation for AIDS Surakarta (MAS) programme, a Red Ribbon campaign that will conduct monthly awareness activities in colleges across Karnataka.

Rather than responding to a surge in infections among students, officials said the campaign aims to increase awareness, encourage voluntary testing and identify people who may be living with HIV without knowing it. Based on estimates by the National AIDS Control Organisation (NACO), Karnataka has about 56,000 people with HIV remain undiagnosed. The campaign encourages residents to use the HIV self-risk assessment QR code available through Break Free India and seek testing at the nearest Integrated Counselling and Testing Centre where required.

Officials said the viral claim stemmed from a misreading of historical treatment records. According to KSAPS, 39,028 HIV-positive people between the ages of 18 and 35 have received Anti-Retroviral Therapy. The depart-

HEALTH AND FAMILY WELFARE MINISTER SAID THERE WAS NO BASIS FOR CLAIMS OF A SPIKE AMONG GENERATION Z OR COLLEGE STUDENTS

ment said that cumulative figure was incorrectly portrayed in some reports as the number of college students recently found to be HIV positive.

Health and family welfare minister UT Khader said students under Generation Z or college students. "Karnataka is implementing an extensive awareness programme with the AIDS cases. Reports claiming that thousands of college students have tested HIV positive are completely false. We have free medicines, records of people tested in both government and private hospitals, and we are introducing a digital system to monitor treatment and ensure free medicines reach every eligible patient," he said.

The department also released recent surveillance data to dispel current infections from cumulative treatment records. Between April and June 2026, 5,543 people from the general population underwent HIV testing, with 3,091 testing positive. During the same period, 2,874 pregnant women were screened, of whom 11 were HIV positive. Khader also questioned the methodology behind NACO's estimate of undiagnosed HIV cases and said Karnataka had sought additional details from the national agency. "Sensitive issues such as HIV cannot be discussed based on assumptions. We have written to NACO seeking the parameters and specific data behind its estimates," he said.

Worker killed in elephant attack

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MANGALURU: A 55-year-old daily wage worker was killed in a wild elephant attack, police said.

The deceased was identified as Balakrishna Gowda, a resident of Idmalu. According to police, Gowda was attacked near Muchiradi in Rekhy village under the limits of the Nethravathi police station late on Saturday evening.

When he failed to return home after work, his family

HE DECEASED WAS IDENTIFIED AS DAILY WAGE WORKER BALAKRISHNA GOWDA

members and residents launched a search.

During the search, they found his mangled body lying on a path, along with elephant footprints, raising fears that he had been attacked by a wild elephant.

After an extensive search by

residents and Forest Department personnel, Gowda's body was recovered from a nearby ravine early on Sunday morning. Senior officials, such as Assistant Conservator of Forests Subbaiah Nallu, Uppinangudi Range Officer Raghuvaran, District H P and Dharmasthala Police Sub-Inspector Samarth Ganigera, visited the spot and inspected the area.

Members of the Arasimanki-Shishila Shaurya Disaster Management Unit also assisted the Forest Department in the recovery operation.

Trekking policy gives livelihood push for tribals

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MANGALURU: For generations, the Malekudiyu people of Karnataka's Western Ghats knew every bend in the forest-trails, every medicinal plant and every bird call. That knowledge rarely translated into economic security. Today, it has become their lifeline.

A new trekking policy introduced by Karnataka's forest department has turned members of the indigenous forest dwellers into guides, creating a steady source of income while placing those most familiar with the landscape at the centre of the value experience.

More than 60 members of the Malekudiyu tribe have been certified to guide trekkers on the Nethravathi Peak trail alone. Others from the community now work on the Kudremukh, Gangadikar and Kunjiraj trekking routes. Across Karnataka, Kudremukh, Sringeri and villages surrounding the Kudremukh forests, more than 350 local guides have found employment as certified trek guides.

Since April 2026, the forest department has required certified guides on all approved trek routes. Every group of ten trekkers must be accompanied by one guide. Daily visitor numbers on major trails are capped

at 300, and bookings are made exclusively through the department's online portal. The policy has opened employment opportunities for communities living inside the forests where the trekking routes are located.

For Malekudiyu Malekudiyu, 50, of Malwanthe village in Belthangudi taluk, the change has altered both how he earns a living and how visitors experience the forest.

Once he walked the Nethravathi Peak trail simply as part of daily life. Now he introduces trekkers to the forest through the names, stories and traditions he grew up with, identifying birds and plants using the Malekudiyu language.

"I started as a guide three years ago. I had no formal training, but whenever I was called by local transport drivers who brought trekkers to the Nethravathi Trek base camp, I would help out. Prior to this, I worked as a daily wage labourer and also on our agricultural land to earn my living. Over the years, as I started to guide, I received less daily wage work. Working as a guide has now helped me earn a good income. On average, I earn about ₹15,000 to ₹20,000 per month when the trek season is on. During the other times, I work on my agricultural land. I have begun guiding for the last two weeks as I am busy ploughing my land," he said.

MORE THAN 60 MEMBERS OF THE MALEKUDIYA TRIBE HAVE BEEN CERTIFIED TO GUIDE TREKKERS ON THE NETHRAVATHI PEAK TRAIL

He is now among those formally trained and certified by the forest department.

Ashok Malekudiyu, 34, from Elanuru village, is among the few people in his community to complete a bachelor's degree. Instead of leaving in search of work elsewhere, he chose to stay. "I never wanted to move out from here. Now, I have worked as a nature guide for three years and was certified a few months ago," he said. "I earn about ₹15,000 to ₹20,000 per month."

For younger members of the community, guiding has become an alternative to agricultural labour.

Nithin Malekudiyu left school after SSLC and now works as a certified guide. Unlike his father, Yadu Malekudiyu, who depended on area nut plantations and other farm labour, he sees tourism as a more secure livelihood.

"Work as a trek guide and get

three to four assignments a week, which helps me earn a good income. The day is out of work, I help my father at home. This initiative has given us a new life; otherwise, we would have relied only on daily wage work. If we were forced to move out in search of better jobs," he said.

His father said previous generations of the tribe, physically demanding agricultural work or the collection of non-timber forest products such as wild honey, shikakai, Malabar tamarind, and other forest products, was an activity that is no longer permitted. He recalled earning only ₹250 for a full day's labour and said many people who climbed area nut trees had suffered life-changing falls. "Compared to this, being a trek guide is a good option," he said.

The community's familiarity with the forest has become its greatest asset. Born and raised in the Western Ghats, the guides possess detailed knowledge of the terrain, wildlife and medicinal plants, which they now share with visitors during the treks. V Sarma of the Belthangudi Wildlife Range said the Nethravathi trek has become a sought-after activity with about 15 certified guides, including 60 from the Malekudiyu community.

Before becoming guides, these members of the tribal community had no proper

income, working as daily wage labourers and doing other agricultural jobs. Some of them even used to travel to the Kalasa and Samsa border areas of Dakshina Kannada and Chikmagalur for work. However, after becoming guides, their lives have changed. Many have a stable income. As per our estimate, each person earns at least a minimum income of ₹12,000 per month. Some have even left their salaries at home for a fixed daily stipend of ₹1,000 per trek," he said.

The Nethravathi Peak trail remains open from June until January or February, depending on the risk of forest fires. The route receives around 300 bookings each day, requiring roughly 30 to 35 guides daily under the one guide for every ten trekkers rule. Some visitors hire a guide even for groups of two or three. Before receiving certification, all selected guides underwent training in personality development, visitor interaction and emergency response, including first aid and CPR, before being issued official certificates.

For a community that had its understanding of the forest built over generations, the work has become more than seasonal employment. Knowledge once passed from parents to children is now helping sustain families while introducing visitors to the landscape through the people who have always called it home.

ASPIRANTS ALLEGE LAPSES IN POLICE HIRING EXAM, STAGE TESTS

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BENGALURU: Protests erupted at a police constable recruitment exam centre in Karnataka's Vijayapura district on Sunday after aspirants alleged lapses in the exam process, with many walking out and demanding a re-examination.

The district administration, however, rejected the allegations, saying the examination was conducted in strict compliance with the Karnataka Examinations Authority Standard Operating Procedure.

Hundreds of candidates at Sharadamba PU College in Tikota boycotted the examination, alleging delays in the distribution of question papers and irregularities in the handling of question papers and OMR sheets. Several aspirants staged a protest outside the centre, alleging that the tapes had adversely affected candidates who had spent years preparing for the recruitment. According to the candidates, the question papers, reached them about 30 minutes late. Sources said candidates who left the examination hall carrying question papers and OMR sheets had violated KFA rules and were not allowed to re-enter.

Key accused in iridium copper fraud arrested

with a best leap of 16.58 metres in freezing conditions, narrowly missing the gold medal.

Acknowledging the close finish, his father said the family had hoped for gold but was immensely proud of his achievement.

"He missed it by a hair's breadth, but that's okay," he said adding, "Next time, my son will certainly win the gold medal and bring greater pride to India and Tamil Nadu." The father, whose daughter works as a teacher and whose two sons are athletes, credited the entire community for Praveen's success.

Looking ahead, Praveen's father said he hoped his son's achievements would inspire the

Drugs can give brief high but make life low: Modi to youth

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday asked the country's youth to take a pledge against substance abuse, saying drugs can give them a "high" for some time, but would make their entire career and personal life "low".

Launching the 'Nasha Mukti Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan', Modi said the country's youth must be mentally and physically fit, for which it is necessary for them to stay away from all kinds of substance abuse.

"Drugs can give you a high for some time, but it makes your entire career and personal life low," he said.

Questioning the taboo around drug addicts, Modi said those who come out of drug addiction are fighters and should be honoured by society.

"Society should respect them, embrace them and give them a second chance," he said.

The prime minister launched the campaign virtually in the presence of a large number of youth, who described themselves as representatives of Gen-Z, days after large-scale protests by students demanding reforms in the



Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the launch of 'Nasha Mukti Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan'.

public examination system reform Delhi and other parts of the country.

"Our culture teaches us that one can get rid of substance abuse with the support of society, yoga and meditation," Modi said.

The 'Nasha Mukti Yuva' campaign is a resolve for the individual, family, society and, most importantly, the nation, and the name of the initiative itself reflects its objective, he said.

"When the country has set the goal of building a developed India, it is essential that the youth stay away from harmful substances to remain physically and mentally healthy and full of self-confidence," Modi said.

"This is the objective of this

campaign," he added, urging everyone to take a pledge to ensure that young people understand the dangers of drug addiction and remain aware and vigilant in every possible way.

"From today, the Nasha Mukti Yuva Abhiyan is being launched across the country. When this becomes a collective campaign, even those who are unable to do something on their own will receive new energy."

The resolve taken today will move forward in the same manner for the next 100 weeks. Every Sunday, activities related to art, culture, sports, meditation, spirituality and service will be organised. The message of de-addiction will reach new people," he said.

The coming 100 Sundays will mark 100 strong steps towards a drug-free India.

The prime minister also said that addiction not only harms the body, but also takes away a mother's smile, shatters a father's dreams, weakens a sister's hope, and takes away the respect of a younger brother.

"Family members live with this pain every day, watching their children gradually lose themselves before their eyes," he said. Modi also said the government stands firmly with the youth in this campaign against drugs.

"Strict action is being taken against drug traffickers across the country. The arrests have gone up several times as compared to

before, and drugs worth thousands of crores of rupees have been seized. This shows how strongly our government is acting against drugs," the PM said.

He also urged families not to hide their children's addiction out of concern for social reputation, and instead communicate openly with them and seek expert and medical help to help them overcome substance abuse.

The 'Nasha Mukti Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan' aims to inspire youth to stay away from substance abuse and encourages them to become ambassadors of positive social change in their communities.

The launch marked the beginning of a 100-week nationwide 'Jan Bhagidari' campaign, under which activities will be organised every Sunday across the country to promote awareness and encourage public participation in building a drug-free society.

The activities will include sports events, walkathons, meditation sessions, cultural programmes, awareness campaigns, nuktas, natakas, discussion forums, and community engagement programmes.

The Nasha Mukti Bharat Abhiyan was launched in 2020 in line with the prime minister's vision of creating a Nasha Mukti Bharat, Union Minister for Sports and Youth Affairs, Mansukh Mandaviya, said at the launch.

SEVERAL STATES URGE YOUTH TO BE DRUG-FREE

NEW DELHI: Chief ministers and governors of several states, including Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Odisha, and Jammu and Kashmir, on Sunday appealed to youngsters to stay away from drugs, echoing PM Narendra Modi's appeal for the country's youth to pledge against substance abuse as he launched the Nasha Mukti Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan.

Uttar Pradesh governor Anandiben Patel urged the youth of the state to play a constructive role to limit themselves to merely staying away from drugs but also to raise awareness among families, friends, and the wider community about the adverse effects of substance abuse.

Madhya Pradesh chief minister Mohan Yadav described substance abuse as the root cause of social ruin and said his government had enforced prohibition in 19 religious towns across the state as part of its fight against addiction.

Rajasthan chief minister Bhajan Lal Sharma urged the youth of the state to play a constructive role in nation-building by staying away from drugs and channelling their energy positively.

HTC AND AGENCIES

CAUVERY WATER ROW | TN TO MOVE TOP COURT

CM Vijay deferred Karnataka suit on my request: DKs

Arum Dev and S Vijay Karthik
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BENGALURU/CHENNAI: Karnataka chief minister DK Shivakumar said on Sunday that his Tamil Nadu counterpart C Joseph Vijay agreed to postpone his visit to Bengaluru on his request amid growing tension over the Cauvery water-sharing dispute, even as a Tamil Nadu minister said the state government would instead move the Supreme Court over the issue as an immediate solution.

Speaking after an all-party meeting over the Cauvery issue, Shivakumar said he had personally urged Vijay to defer his visit because public sentiment in Karnataka was running high.

I only requested that we meet in a better and more cordial atmosphere because I don't want anyone shouting against my friends. We should respect each other. We have to live together and work together. Ultimately, India is one," Shivakumar said.

Meanwhile, Tamil Nadu minister Arum Dev said he had personally urged Vijay to postpone his visit because public sentiment in Karnataka was running high.

"After filing of the case, the CM will certainly engage in



DK Shivakumar and C Joseph Vijay

efforts for friendly relations," Kumar said, indicating that Vijay would take up the visit later.

The Cauvery dispute is a long-running water-sharing conflict between Karnataka and Tamil Nadu, with both states contesting allocations from the river, especially in deficit years.

The issue resurfaced amid developments concerning the Mekedatu balancing reservoir project, proposed by Karnataka, a major point of friction between the two states, with Tamil Nadu opposing it because it would affect the flow of water downstream.

Shivakumar also defended Karnataka's compliance with the Cauvery Water Management Authority's direction to release 3,500 cusecs of water to Tamil Nadu every day for 15 days, saying the state was honouring the order despite the difficulties created by deficient rainfall.

"We are closely watching the situation. We respect the sentiments of the people and the law of the country. As per the order passed, we are releasing water, and I hope there will be no problem," Shivakumar said.

He again described the pro-

posed Mekedatu balancing reservoir as the long-term answer to the Cauvery dispute, arguing that Tamil Nadu would receive most of its advantages.

"If the Mekedatu reservoir is built, nearly 90% of the benefit will go to Tamil Nadu, more than Karnataka. At no point can that water be diverted back to Bengaluru. Anyone can visit the project site and understand the facts," Shivakumar said.

Tamil Nadu minister Kumar took a swipe at the DMK for moving the Supreme Court over the issue. "By the afternoon (Saturday), government lawyer who has been handling this case in the SC for many years was informed. While it was still in the process, the DMK hastily filed a case against it because it would affect the flow of water downstream," he said.

Alleging that the DMK family and Shivakumar have been in a "very bad relationship" and it goes beyond party lines, Kumar said, "many quarters have been saying that rather than listening to the Congress leadership, DK Shivakumar listens more to (DMK chief) MK Stalin. And that is exactly how things have been unfolding over the past week."

Shivakumar rejected accusations that his government was acting in the interests of either Tamil Nadu or the DMK, saying Karnataka would safeguard its own interests while maintaining friendly ties with its neighbour. "For me, Tamil Nadu is one, and Karnataka is one. Ultimately, we are one," he said.

BSP expels ex-MP Siddharth again; says won't get re-entry

HT Correspondent

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LUCKNOW: Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) national president Mayawati on Sunday expelled senior party leader and former Rajya Sabha MP Ashok Siddharth from the party on charges of anti-party activities for the second time in nearly 18 months and made it clear he will not be taken back into the party under any circumstances in the future.

National coordinator Randhir Singh Beniwal, who was in-charge of the party in Punjab, Jammu and Kashmir and Himachal Pradesh, had earlier expelled Siddharth from the party in February 2025 and reinstated him in September 2025.



Mayawati and Ashok Siddharth

Siddharth is the father-in-law of Ashok Anand, Mayawati's nephew and BSP national convener. Siddharth was in charge of party affairs in Karnataka, Delhi, Gujarat, Odisha and West Bengal.

Mayawati had expelled Siddharth from the party in February 2025 and reinstated him in September 2025.

tember of that year.

In a post on X on Sunday, Mayawati said he did not fulfil his duties properly in the state where he was given responsibility as a BSP coordinator. "Not only in Karnataka but also from Odisha and West Bengal, reports of his indiscipline—that is, violation of party discipline—kept coming in continuously. Since no improvement was observed despite repeated warnings, Ashok Siddharth was removed from the party possibilities on Saturday," she said.

After this, the reports of his return to UP are a deliberate conspiracy to create confusion within the party and affect the campaign for the upcoming UP assembly elections, the BSP president said.

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LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh legislature's monsoon session is set to begin on Monday, with chief minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday urging representatives from both the ruling party and the opposition to raise every issue concerning public interest in the House.

Addressing an all-party meeting chaired by UP legislative assembly speaker Satish Mahana at the Vidhan Bhawan, Adityanath said, "The monsoon session should witness constructive discussions on issues concerning the common people. Such deliberations, he said, contribute to the state's development and help resolve public grievances."

During the all-party meeting, leaders of Opposition parties



UP CM Yogi Adityanath wears VR goggles during the unveiling of the Legislative Council's digital library, in Lucknow on Sunday.

requested CM Adityanath to extend the duration of the monsoon session, which will end on August 14, at least till August 14 keeping in view the number of issues of public interest to be

raised in the House. The monsoon session will end on Thursday after giving the nod to the state government's first supplementary budget for 2026-27 and carrying out legislative business.

Meanwhile, the monsoon session is set to witness the Opposition raise issues concerning the alleged embezzlement of devotees' offerings at the Ram temple in Ayodhya and the action taken against students protesting over paper leaks in the state. Both the issues have remained in political focus in recent weeks. Other issues to be raised include the law and order situation, crime against women, inflation, unemployment and shortage of fertilisers.

This became evident as Samajwadi Party's (SP) MP Malla Prasad Pandey, said party president Akhilesh Yadav announced on Sunday.

K'TAKA CABINET EXPANSION IN LIMBO OVER CONG BRASS APPROVAL

HT Correspondent

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BENGALURU: The Congress leadership is yet to give formal approval to Karnataka's expanded ministry, leaving the state's Cabinet composition under uncertainty as preparations continue for an oath-taking ceremony that party leaders hope to hold after the final list reaches Bengaluru, leaders in the appropriate time.

Chief minister DK Shivakumar has submitted a proposed list of 20 legislators to the Congress leadership following a request from the party in New Delhi, they said, adding that another round of consultations is expected before the names receive final clearance.

The party has informed Shivakumar that the approved list is likely to be communicated by Monday, the people said.

If that happens, the swearing-in ceremony is expected to take place later in the day at Lok Bhavan, where arrangements have already begun. However, government officials have not announced the official schedule.

Shivakumar said, "The cabinet expansion is certain. But the specific date will be announced at the appropriate time." Home Minister Priyanka Kharge indicated that the exercise was nearing completion after announcing the list of new ministers.

"The state cabinet will be expanded tomorrow (Monday). A new cabinet will be formed tomorrow (Monday)," he said.

Slipper hurled at Bihar MP over Parl skit

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NEW DELHI: A man allegedly threw a slipper at Independent MP Yadav during a press conference at the Pandara Rao house on Sunday after the lawmaker defended his controversial skit at the Parliament House complex on the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple, leading to a scuffle between his supporters and the attacker.



Pappu Yadav with the alleged attacker (centre) and a police officer in New Delhi.

The MP from Bihar's Purnia was addressing the presser amid

threw a slipper at Yadav, who was addressing the presser amid

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PM Modi remembers Pingali Venkayya on 150th birth anniversary

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday paid tributes to Pingali Venkayya on his 150th birth anniversary and remembered his invaluable role in giving the country its national flag. A freedom fighter, Venkayya is known for designing the initial version of the national flag, was honoured by the PM on his 150th birth anniversary. The PM said, "Venkayya was an inspire people to serve our country with dedication and patriotic fervour," the PM said in a social media post.

Ex-BJP MP returns to teaching profession, rejoins Tripura school

AGARTTA: Former BJP Lok Sabha MP Rehati Tripathi has returned to his teaching profession after a decade in politics, rejoining Mahatma Gandhi Memorial School in Agartta on July 20, Rehati, a political science teacher, postgraduate, won the 2019 Lok Sabha polls from East Tripura, but was not fielded by the BJP in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. He was the headmaster of the school Tita Saha said Rehati is doing his duty with full dedication.

AS Rajeev to act as chief vigilance commissioner

NEW DELHI: Vigilance commissioner AS Rajeev will act as the Central Vigilance Commissioner beginning Monday, the government said in a notification. The current Central Vigilance Commissioner Praveen Kumar Srivastava is completing his tenure on August 3. Rajeev will assume charge until the appointment of the CVC, the Department of Personnel (DoP) notification said.

Ahead of polls, Pb BJP announces major rejig

Ravinder Vasudeva

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CHANDIGARH: With an eye on the Punjab assembly elections next week, the Punjab unit of Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday announced a major organisational reshuffle, with newly-appointed state president Kaul Singh Dhillon unveiling his team that seeks to strike a balance between seasoned party leaders and fresh faces.

The development came a day before the Punjab assembly was set to convene for the monsoon session.

The reshuffle in the party ranks just weeks after Dhillon was named BJP's first-ever state president from the Jat Sikh community, signalling the party's intent to expand its reach among Punjab's rural and Sikh electorate after its split with the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD).

However, the newly constituted team continues to be dominated by leaders from Hindu and other communities, indicat-

ing that the party has largely retained its existing organisational framework while accommodating new social and political representation.

The party has appointed 12 state vice-presidents and an equal number of state secretaries. The organisational revamp is part of the BJP's strategy to strengthen its independent political base in Punjab following the collapse of its nearly three-decade alliance with the SAD in September 2020 over the Centre's now-released farm laws.

Since then, the party has been working to broaden its support beyond its traditional urban vote bank comprising traders, Hindu voters and sections of the Dalit community.

The BJP's first solo contest in the 2022 Punjab assembly elections yielded disappointing results, with the party winning only two seats and securing a 6.6% vote share. The SAD also suffered its worst-ever electoral performance, winning just three seats in the 117-member assembly.

Slogans at Cong event expose rift in Punjab

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BARNALA: Supporters of former chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi raised slogans during the party's 'Har Bhoth, Congress Mazboot' programme in Barnala, exposing yet again the simmering factionalism in the Punjab Congress. Similar slogans had been raised during the campaign in Patiala and Sangrur on Saturday.

Significantly, the incident took place in the presence of AICC general secretary and Punjab in-charge Bhupesh Baghel, Punjab Congress president Anshu Kumar, and Punjab MLA Kuldeep Singh Kalia Dhillon and other state leaders.

The programme was briefly disrupted when a group of Channi supporters raised slogans including 'Channi reit soch te pehra deyanthe tok ke' and 'Charanjit Singh Zindabad.' As the sloganeering continued, Warring appealed to party workers to maintain discipline. Dhillon

also stepped down from the stage in an effort to pacify the slogan-shouting supporters. Later, addressing reporters, Warring sought to downplay the incident, saying the message is clear—we have to strengthen every booth," Baghel said.

"The person raising the slogan could be an outsider, could be one of our own workers, or could even have been sent by chief minister Bhagwant Singh Mann," Warring said.

Addressing the media after the programme, Baghel said the 'Har Bhoth, Congress Mazboot' campaign, was receiving an encouraging response from party workers. "The message is clear—we have to strengthen every booth," Baghel said.

The latest developments follow the Congress high command's July 1 decision to retain Warring as Punjab Congress president while appointing Channi as chairman of the party's campaign committee. In a move to isolate competing power centres within the party,

Vehicle link proof key for VA claim: SC

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NEW DELHI: Can the family of a murder victim claim compensation under the Motor Vehicles Act (MVA) merely because the crime took place inside a motor vehicle? The Supreme Court has answered that question by drawing a fine but significant distinction between the commission of a crime inside a vehicle and an accident arising out of the use of a motor vehicle, holding that the mere presence of a vehicle in the chain of events is insufficient to attract liability under the Act.

A bench of justices Sanjay Karol and Augustine George Masih held that a claimant seeking compensation under the MVA must establish a causal nexus between the use of the motor vehicle and the death or injury. Where that link is missing, compensation cannot be awarded merely because the offence was committed in, or involved, a vehicle.

The ruling came in a case where the deceased, had left in a car driven by a person

known to him, Dilip, and was found dead three days later. The deceased's family alleged that Anand was murdered while travelling in the vehicle and sought compensation under the MVA. While the Motor Accident Claims Tribunal and the high court found the claim, the Supreme Court reversed both decisions, finding no evidence to establish that the death had arisen out of the use of the vehicle.

The bench noted that the claimant's evidence had failed to establish the "last seen" theory against the accused and that there was no forensic material connecting the car to the murder. There was no evidence of blood stains, hair, skin cells or any indication that the vehicle had been involved in a collision or any other event resulting in the fatal injuries.

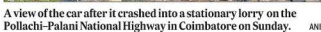
"Simply because there was a car somehow involved in a chain of circumstances that led to the death, it does not mean that the vehicle itself played any role in causing the death," the bench held in its July 22 judgment.

The judgment revisits an important line of precedent beginning with Ritu Devi Vs New India Assurance Co Ltd (2009), where the top court had evolved the concept of an "accidental murder". In that case, the court held that where murder is committed in the course of another felonious act, such as theft of a vehicle, it may still qualify as an accident under the MVA because the dominant intention was not to kill but to facilitate the theft.

Explaining that distinction, the bench quoted the 2009 verdict, which held that if "the dominant intention" is to kill a particular person, the offence is a murder simpliciter. However, if the

killing occurs in furtherance of another crime, the murder may assume the character of an accidental murder for the purposes of compensation law. The bench, however, said that principle could not be mechanically applied to every case involving a vehicle.

"We are of the considered view that this distinction between primary and secondary felonious acts cannot be made in the present case," it noted, pointing out that the record contained no evidence demonstrating how or where the fatal injuries were inflicted or that the vehicle itself played any role in causing the death. The court also clarified the evidentiary threshold applicable to compensation claims before the Tribunals. Unlike criminal trials, where guilt must be established beyond reasonable doubt, compensation proceedings are decided on the civil standard of "preponderance of probabilities". Even under this relatively lower standard, however, the claimant must prove a sufficient nexus between the accident and the use of the motor vehicle.





Incessant rains have led to flooding of several towns in Kerala.

Major towns in Kerala flooded; Meghalaya sees its 'driest' spell

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Major towns in Kerala and large swathes of rural areas, experienced widespread flooding and waterlogging following incessant heavy rains on Sunday, taking the death toll in rain-related incidents up to eight even as eight others were missing, officials said.

Though the intensity of the rains eased on Sunday, floodwaters did not recede from major urban centres in the state including towns such as Arannamulla and Ranni, leading to members of the public, MLAs along with NDRF personnel and volunteers joining hands to clear solid waste and remove clogged drains.

A release from the CM's office said the death toll from rain-related incidents since Friday climbed to eight with eight others reported missing, including fishermen who ventured to sea from the Muthalappuzha harbour. While 13 people were injured, a total of 5,792 persons have been shifted to relief camps from flood and landslide prone zones.

"Public must continue to remain alert especially in hilly areas. Though the magnitude of the rains has decreased, measures have been taken to deal with any situation that emerges. The government promises relief and financial assistance to those who have been affected in the rain-related incidents," the CM said.

Meanwhile, the flood situation in Assam improved slightly, with the number of affected people coming down to 178,000 even though the count of districts hit by the deluge increased to seven, officials said on Sunday. At least 85 people died in this year's deluge, officials said.

Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said the state government will engage IIT-Guwahati for developing a long-term solution to the erosion problem of the Brahmaputra river.

Meghalaya, known for its rain-soaked landscapes and home to some of the wettest places on Earth, is experiencing one of its driest monsoon spells in years, with the state recording a staggering 58% rainfall deficit during the core monsoon season, according to the latest data released by IMD.

Between June 1 and July 31, the state received only 681.5 mm of rain against the seasonal normal of 1,628 mm, placing Meghalaya in the IMD's 'Deficient' rainfall category and triggering concerns over agriculture, drinking water supply and reservoir storage if the dry spell continues.

With agencies inputs

{ TOP COURT TELLS CENTRE, STATES }

'Verify, demarcate wetlands in SAC Atlas within 2 mths'

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has tightened its oversight of the protection of India's wetlands, directing the Centre, states and Union territories to actively verify and demarcate all wetlands identified in the Space Applications Centre (SAC) Atlas within two months, while warning that secretaries and other senior officials will be summoned to court if the exercise remains confined to paperwork.

A bench of Justices Arvind Kumar and Vipul M Pandhi made it clear that the statutory exercise of "ground-truthing" and boundary demarcation under the Wetlands (Conservation and Management) Rules, 2007, cannot be completed merely on paper and must involve physical identification of the wetlands on the ground. The court said that demarcation of wetland boundary should not only be on paper but also to be physically carried out and identification of such wetlands or water bodies as identified by the SAC Atlas shall be undertaken by the states if not already undertaken and a report be filed before this court expeditiously and at any rate within an outer limit of two months," the bench directed in an order passed on July 28 and released on Saturday.

"This exercise of physical verification if not undertaken, the Secretaries of Ministry of Environment and Forest and the Vice Chairman of the respective State Wetland Authorities shall appear in person on the next date of hearing and show cause as to why further steps should not be taken by this court for non-compliance," the court said, adding that any breach of this or previous directions would be viewed "very seriously".

The latest order marks a significant escalation in litigation the top court has been monitoring since

{ SUPREME COURT }

Ground truthing and demarcation of wetland boundary should not only be on paper but also to be physically carried out...



2018 to ensure the identification, notification and protection of wetlands across the country. The proceedings arise from a batch of public interest litigations filed by Greater Noida-based Arya and environmentalist Anand Arya, advocate MK Balakrishnan and NGO Vanashakti.

The court recalled that as far back as December 11, 2024, it had directed every state and UT Wetland Authority to complete "ground-truthing" and boundary demarcation of all wetlands identified in the 2021 SAC Atlas within three months, describing it as a statutory obligation under the Wetlands Rules. Those directions were reiterated in subsequent orders dated August 19, October 7 and October 28, 2025.

However, senior advocates Jayant Bhusan and Anitha Shenoy, appearing for the petitioners, informed the court that while several states claimed compliance, the exercise had largely remained a desk exercise. According to them, wetlands identified through satellite imagery had neither been physically inspected nor verified on site, defeating the very objective of ground-truthing before demarcation.

Accepting the submission, the bench observed that despite its repeated orders, some states and

their wetland authorities were attempting to take a position contrary to the court's directions. "When our order dated 11.12.2024 which has been reiterated on 19.08.2025, 07.10.2025 and 28.10.2025 is clear, we fail to understand as to how the states or its instrumentalities or the Wetland Authorities, can take a different view," the bench said before directing that both ground-truthing and demarcation should not only be on paper but also to be physically carried out.

The direction effectively gives all states and UTs a final two-month window to complete physical verification of every wetland or water body mapped in the SAC Atlas and place compliance reports before the court.

The litigation concerns wetlands identified by the Space Applications Centre under ISRO's Wetland Atlas. Earlier proceedings revealed that the number of wetlands larger than 2.25 hectares had risen from 201,503 in earlier inventories to 231,195 in the 2021 Atlas, making physical verification essential before legal protection could be extended.

In August 2025, the court had expressed dissatisfaction over the pace of compliance after a status report filed by the Union government showed several states had

made little progress in ground-truthing and boundary demarcation. Calling the progress "snail's pace", it had granted another two months while cautioning that environment secretaries of defaulting states would have to personally appear before the court if the exercise remained incomplete. It had also directed states to publish details of identified wetlands, completed ground-truthing and boundary demarcation on their official websites and asked the Centre to coordinate with states for expeditious issuance of wetland notifications.

The court had further clarified in October 2025 that the process of ground-truthing and demarcation must strictly comply with Rule 7 of the Wetlands (Conservation and Management) Rules, 2007 after concerns were raised that some authorities were carrying out demarcation before undertaking physical verification.

Apart from strengthening compliance directions, the bench also reappointed advocate Shibani Ghosh as nodal counsel to coordinate pleadings among all parties, state governments and wetland authorities in view of the voluminous record generated in the long-pending proceedings.

The bench also dealt with several intervention applications filed by Balakrishnan, who appeared in person seeking court directions for restoration of over 1,000 lands in Vrindavan and a nationwide river-bank waste management project.

While acknowledging that the causes sought to be espoused were "laudable" and "benevolent", the court refused to direct release of ₹80 crore and ₹1,038 lakh crore, respectively, to the intervenor, observing that such work falls within the domain of statutory authorities and state governments. It, however, said the concerns raised regarding the protection of water bodies and river ecosystems would be kept in view while passing final orders in the main matter.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of

HT TWTW THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

HT FIRST VOICE LAST WORD

{ ASSAM }

15-year-old found dead, kin allege rape, murder

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SILCHAR: A 15-year-old girl was found dead at her home near National Highway-6 in Assam's Hailakandi district, with her family alleging she was raped and murdered, police said on Sunday, adding that four people have been detained for questioning in the incident.

The victim's sister alleged that the victim was sexually assaulted before being murdered, the SSP said the allegations are yet to be established medically.

"The family members are claiming it [rape], but we are waiting for the post-mortem report to draw any conclusions. We are investigating the matter, and four persons are currently being questioned," Sinha said.

The incident took place in the Aitoli area under Katikhat police station at 11pm on Saturday. The victim's family said they

were attending a feast at a nearby relative's house at the time. "It's a neighbourhood where many members of the same extended family live together, and her family members were not far when the incident took place," the SSP said. "She was there at the feast too, but after an argument with a cousin, she left for home at 10.30pm. But when we reached home around an hour later, it was a horrible scene," her mother said, adding that her body was found lying on the floor, almost unrecognisable.

The victim's sister alleged that the attackers used utensils and other objects to mutilate the body. "Her face was smashed, her head was bludgeoned with a heavy object, and some rod-like object was inserted into her private parts," she said.

Police said they received the information around 12.30am, and recovered the body on Sunday morning after protests by family and neighbours. Locals initially refused to hand over the body to the police, but later the body was transported to Silchar hospital for autopsy, police said.

{ DUAL USE AGRICULTURE }

Centre tests farming beneath elevated solar panels

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NEW DELHI: The Centre is testing whether the country's vast agricultural landscape can be tapped to produce both food and electricity through agrivoltaics—a system that grows crops beneath elevated solar panels. With pilots already in place, advisors for the use of this tech may be launched as early as next harvest season, according to officials involved in the project.

Of the almost 37 pilot studies running across the country, the benchmark Indian Agricultural Research Institute's (IARI) study has completed its first season of crop trials, with preliminary findings suggesting that while leafy vegetables appear well suited to cultivation under solar panels, cereals such as rice and wheat may be more sensitive to shading, a senior Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) official told HT.

According to another official of the agriculture ministry, "mustard showed great promise".

The research centres for the government schemes for ways to rapidly expand solar power generation without triggering conflicts over land use. Solar will have to account for much of India's future renewable energy additions, requiring annual capacity additions of roughly 35-40 GW, but acquiring large contiguous tracts of land for conventional solar parks has increasingly become a challenge.

"Agrivoltaics offers the possibility of producing food and electricity from the same parcel of land," PS Brahmamandam, Project

What are Agrivoltaics?

Agrivoltaics (AgriPV) is a farming system in which solar panels are installed on elevated structures allowing crops to be cultivated underneath while electricity is generated above



HOW THEY WORK
Solar panels are mounted about three metres above the ground. Tractors and farm equipment can continue operating beneath the structures. Farmers cultivate crops while also earning income from electricity generation.

140 mn hectares Total agricultural land	220 mn hectares Gross cropped area
1,192 GW-2,129 GW Estimated agrivoltaics potential	15-20% Farmland sufficient for meeting solar targets

Director of the Centre of Excellence on Agrivoltaics at IARI, told HT, explaining that the objective is to generate scientific evidence that can guide large-scale deployment. The Centre of Excellence, established with support from the MNRE, the National Institute of Solar Energy and Germany's GIZ, has so far tested growing crops, including cauliflower, cabbage, spinach, mustard and other vegetables beneath elevated solar structures. Fresh trials during the ongoing kharif season will expand the work to vegetables, paddy, and selected millets before scientists begin drawing conclusions across multiple seasons.

Brahmamandam says the project is intended to answer questions that have so far prevented agrivoltaics from moving beyond experi-

mental projects in India. "Rather than identifying a handful of suitable crops, we hope to develop a crop suitability matrix for different agro-climatic zones, quantify the impact on yields, estimate power savings, evaluate additional farm income from electricity generation and design commercially viable models suited to India's predominantly smallholder landings," he said. "The science is more complex than simply determining whether crops can tolerate shade."

The findings will be compounded over the next two years and the technology will be launched at a mass scale thereafter, he said.

Some crops are already expected to perform better than others, Brahmamandam, however, stresses that even crops currently

viewed as less suitable should not be ruled out until complete data is available.

The efforts come after a 2023 government-backed assessment of agrivoltaics, which concluded that although India had begun experimenting with the concept, most projects remained demographically and several critical questions needed to be answered before large-scale deployment could be considered. The study had called for more research on crop suitability, business models, farmer participation, recommendations that have since informed the establishment of dedicated research facilities such as the IARI Centre of Excellence.

India's agricultural landscape makes such research particularly significant. The country has about 140 million hectares of agricultural land and roughly 220 million hectares of gross cropped area, making farming the country's largest contiguous land resource. Instead of acquiring new land for solar parks, agrivoltaics seeks to generate electricity while allowing cultivation to continue on the same fields.

The potential is substantial. In a Lok Sabha reply this week, the government said studies by institutions including The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI) estimate India's theoretical agrivoltaic potential at 1,192 GW to 2,129 GW.

The farm economics
India's crop profile will also determine where agrivoltaics is deployed first. India sees multiple crops being grown on the same land in different seasons.

The objective, researchers say, is to prioritise crops and regions where agrivoltaics delivers the greatest combined benefit in terms of electricity generation, agricultural productivity and farmer incomes rather than attempting universal adoption from the outset.

Importantly, scientists say India will not need to convert all of its farmland to meet its renewable energy ambitions. "You don't require the entire agricultural area. A considerable share of around 15% to 20%, would be sufficient," Brahmamandam said, adding that deployment should focus on locations where both solar generation and farming can coexist.

Brahmamandam says one of the Centre's biggest objectives is to generate region-specific recommendations rather than a one-size-fits-all model.

Centre revives Bharat Atta, Rice to temper price rise

Pallavi Singh

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NEW DELHI: The Centre has allocated fresh allocations of subsidised Bharat Atta and Bharat Rice as it seeks to temper a gradual rise in the prices of key household staples, according to an official order seen by HT. While the initial allocation is modest, traders and analysts said the move signals that the government has moved away from a hands-off market intervention if prices continue to firm.

Although no date has been fixed for the retail launch, the government has already allocated wheat and rice to central cooperative agencies for processing into Bharat-branded products, indicating that preparations for the rollout are underway.

The order, issued on July 28,

allocates 50,000 tonnes of wheat and 300,000 tonnes of rice for retail sale through government cooperatives NAFED and NCCF as well as Kendriya Bhandar under the Open Market Sale Scheme (Domestic).

As per the order, Bharat Atta will be sold at ₹25 per kg in 5-kg and 10-kg packs. Bharat Rice will be priced at ₹33 per kg in 30-kg packs and ₹35 per kg in 5-kg and 10-kg packs until October 31, after which the price for the smaller packs will be revised to ₹36 per kg. The government will provide a ₹2.35-per-kg subsidy from the Price Stabilisation Fund on wheat supplied for Bharat Atta.

The fresh allocation is significantly smaller than those made during the earlier phases of the Bharat brand programme. Since its launch in 2023, the Centre has

allocated more than 2.01 million tonnes of wheat and 1.87 million tonnes of rice for Bharat Atta and Bharat Rice, of which nearly 1.89 million tonnes of wheat and 1.73 million tonnes of rice had been sold by March this year, according to a Lok Sabha reply.

The government appears to be starting cautiously. Prices have firmed but are still within its comfort zone, so the initial allocation is more a signal to the market than a large supply intervention. If needed, allocations can be scaled up quickly," a former government secretary said, requesting anonymity.

People in the trade industry said the small quantity is unlikely to have a significant impact on supplies by itself but serves as a signal that the government is prepared to intervene quickly if prices move beyond its

comfort zone.

As of July 31, retail rice prices have risen more than 5% over the past year and about 2% in the past month to around ₹45 per kg. Wheat flour prices have also edged up, increasing about 1% both year-on-year and month-on-month to ₹37 per kg, according to data from the consumer affairs daily price monitoring portal.

The decision comes even though government granaries are significantly better stocked than a year ago. The Food Corporation of India held 52.2 million tonnes of wheat on July 1, up nearly 46% from 35.9 million tonnes a year earlier and well above the prescribed buffer norm of 27.58 million tonnes for the July-October quarter. Rice stocks stood at 40.3 million tonnes, the highest level recorded since 1998.

The comfortable stock position gives the government sufficient room to intervene through retail sales or larger open market auctions if wheat prices rise sharply in the core monsoon, said Sandeep Bansal, Director at Shree godvaran flour mills in Mathura. Multiple traders and market experts told HT that the Centre may eventually have to sell at least 8 million tonnes of wheat through the open market during 2026-27.

The Bharat brand programme also covered pulses. Bharat Chana Dal, followed by Bharat Moong Dal and Bharat Masur Dal, was introduced between 2023 and 2025 to moderate retail pulse prices. More than 1.4 million tonnes of Bharat Chana Dal were sold across two phases before subsidised Bharat Dal sales were discontinued in April 2025 after pulse prices stabilised.

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Hindustan Times

NEW DELHI THURSDAY MAY 28, 2026

NUMBER THEORY

What is the actual economic inequality in India?

By Roshan Kishore and Abhishek Jha

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged Indians to cut down on gold purchases and foreign travel amid concerns over India's external balance, he was subtly hinting towards a deeper problem in the Indian economy. There is now a significant cohort of Indians whose lifestyle is at par with the rich in high-income countries and who are way ahead of how ordinary Indians earn and spend. This cohort seems to have become bigger over time, as is seen in India's rising trade deficit after economic reforms. But, statistically economic reforms, how does one square this (counter-intuitive statistical) circle on inequality? Let us begin with the numbers themselves.

1 The really-rich have seen the lowest increase in spending after reforms

India's first income survey is in the process of being conducted. Existing estimates of inequality are based on consumption expenditure surveys (CES) conducted by the National Statistical Office (NSO). Comparing the monthly per capita expenditure (MPCE) of the entire CES, top 10%, top 5% and top 1% between 1993-94 and 2023-24 CES reveals – the earliest and latest after 1991 reforms – shows that top 1% have seen the lowest proportionate increase in their MPCE. The catch up of the masses vis-a-vis the classes is almost entirely a result of the former's high growth in non-food spending.

Consumption growth between 2023-24 & 1993-94

Chart shows ratio of Monthly Per Capita Expenditure between 2023-24 and 1993-94

Category	Top 1%	Top 5%	Top 10%	All classes
Total	11.1	12.9	13.6	15.3
Food	10.7	10.5	10.6	11.2
Non-Food	11.3	14.6	15.9	21.6

2 Inequality seems to have fallen even within the rich

Thanks to the trend described above, India's consumption inequality has fallen in the post-reform period. The Gini coefficient – the most widespread statistical measure of inequality where 0 shows perfect equality and 1 perfect inequality – has fallen from 0.32 in 1993-94 to 0.29 in 2023-24.

What about inequality within the really rich though? It makes sense to ask this question because it is eminently likely that the super-rich (those who own the rich (say, those who own a car) and only the former has seen income rise. Data seems to suggest otherwise once again. Intra-class Gini has seen the sharpest fall among the richest classes between 1993-94 and 2023-24.

Within-class Gini coefficient of MPCE

Category	Top 1%	Top 5%	Top 10%	Overall
1993-94	0.28	0.24	0.23	0.33
2023-24	0.15	0.17	0.18	0.29

3 Is the CES data just counter-intuitive or really not representative?

This is the crux of the debate around India's official inequality estimate. If the CES does not underestimate inequality, going deeper into the data buttresses theories of the survey undercounting the really rich. For example, the most expensive vehicle bought by a household in the 2023-24 household consumption expenditure survey (HCES) cost just Rs 45 lakh. The share of such households in the HCES is eight households per million. This does not really seem to fit consumption standard of India's super rich. For example, according to the Ministry of Road Transport, Vehicle and Roadways, 4,128 Jaguar, 877 Porsche, 52 Maserati, 11 McLaren, and six Aston Martin four wheelers were registered in the country in FY 2023-24. That typically sell cars priced significantly above Rs 45 lakh in India. This non-exhaustive count of 5,205 registrations amounts to a share of 16 households per million using population projections and household size from the HCES. The CES might be undercounting the rich at a wider level than just luxury cars. The share of households/population who spent on air travel in 2011-12 and 2023-24 shows a decline from 649 households/75 people per million to 471 households/60 people per million. The number of domestic air passengers in India increased from 68.6 million to 153.7 million during this period, according to the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), which translates to roughly 49,993 departures per million and 1,30,381 departures per million people in 2011-12 and 2023-24 respectively. This means that the average Indian air traveller would have to take 230 trips in 2024-25 instead of 65 in 2011-12 annually for the 16.25 data to be correct.

Domestic air passengers and estimated air travellers

Year	Domestic air passengers per million people (DGCA)	Estimated air ticket buyers per million people (CESHS)
2011-12	774.8	49,993.26
2023-24	469.04	110,390.58

Source: CES 2014-15, CES 2023-24, DGCA, National Commission on Population

If the CES is undercounting air travellers, can it be trusted to represent people spending on even higher value goods and services? And if the super rich are undercounted, how credible are its estimates of economic inequality? This does not, however, mean the CES is a useless statistical database. Sure, it tends to undercount the rich, but it also gives a treasure trove of information on the economic condition of a vast majority of Indians. The numbers above only tell us that one should take the inequality measures from the CES data with some amount of skepticism.

LOCAL TERRORIST IN J&K

forces killed Zakir Ahmed Ganeil, a Category A Lashkar-e-Taiba terrorist, on July 8 in a forested area of Anantnag district.

Officials said Ganeil and Bhat were moving through the area when security forces intercepted them.

The joint operation was launched then because of intelligence inputs that Ganeil and Bhatt, who worked together, planned to disrupt the Amarnath Yatra. This was part of Operation Sherwall launched jointly by the forces. Bhatt managed to flee the cordon while Ganeil was neutralised. Since then, security forces have pinned his involvement on the July 22 killing of the J&K head constable and the recent killing of the two migrants. He is the most wanted across J&K, a senior security force officer said, adding that Bhatt is also being aided by other locals.

Officials also pointed to similarities between the July 22 killing of head constable Ashiq Hussain and that of the two migrants Bhupendra Bhaina and Deepak Ratte on Friday. The assailant in both cases was wearing a cap and carried the weapon in a gunny bag.

Witnesses told investigators that the assailant in both cases fired at point-blank range.

Security agencies say little is known about how Bhatt joined the LeT, a poster circulated on social media by unidentified handles shows his joining the Kashmir Revolution Army (KRA) on November 17, 2025. All these months he was working with Lashkar commander Ganeil. He has escaped twice, first during a similar joint operation launched in Anantnag district in the last week of December 2025. Ganeil and Bhatt are both from the same district in south Kashmir's Kulgam. Ganeil had left his house in 2023. Bhatt had left his house for some months in early 2025. This must be the period when he got radicalised and inducted into the KRA," said the officer quoted earlier, adding that KRA is an LeT offshoot, similar to the Resistance Front, which LeT formed to deflect attention from Pakistan.

CENTRE TO PUSH A BILLS

tradition of births and deaths in under five minutes amid continued disruptions.

Parliamentary affairs minister

ter Kiren Rijiju rejected the Opposition's charge that the government was steamrolling legislation, arguing that repeated disruptions had left little scope for debate.

"You say that the government passes bills by steamrolling them through... You cannot make this allegation, because you have missed your opportunity... Regarding any bills we bring forward in the future, if you create such a ruckus over them as well, it will not be good at all... Therefore, please cooperate and do not create a ruckus," Rijiju said.

The Opposition is expected to continue raising both issues when Parliament reconvenes on Monday.

While the Congress has intensified its attack on the BJP over the alleged embezzlement of Ram Mandir donations, Opposition parties are also demanding that Shah make a statement in Parliament on the violence against students in Delhi during a protest march to Parliament on July 20.

According to Opposition leaders, the government is also expected to take up the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill for passage later in the session.

They contend that the proposed legislation would empower authorities to take control of assets created using foreign contributions if an organisation fails to renew its FCRA registration.

Tripartite Congress Rajya Sabha floor leader Derek O'Brien said the proposed legislation should be referred to a parliamentary committee for detailed scrutiny.

Meanwhile, the Congress on Sunday sharpened its attack over the alleged Ram Mandir donation theft, accusing the BJP of exploiting the temple issue for political gain.

"The BJP never wanted the Ram Temple to be built; it only wanted the issue of the Ram Temple," their benefit lay in keeping the temple issue alive — ensuring that violence continued and the demands persisted," Deputy Leader of the Opposition Pramod Tiwari said.

He also alleged that the temple was inaugurated before completion because of electoral considerations.

In June, allegations surfaced that donations received at the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya had been embezzled.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

An SIT constituted at the request of the Shri Ram Janambhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust submitted a preliminary report, following which Ayodhya police registered an FIR against eight people accused of siphoning off donations during the counting process.

The Uttar Pradesh government subsequently reconstituted the SIT, pursuant to a Supreme Court direction, appointing Inspector General (Lucknow Range) Kiran S to head a fresh three-member panel.

Opposition floor leaders will meet on Monday morning to finalise their strategy for the week, with parties expected to continue pressing for Shah's statement while opposing the government's legislative agenda.

U.S.-IRAN WAR

rise, causing energy prices to rise and stoking broader inflation.

Eli Cohen, Israel's energy minister and a member of Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's security cabinet, said there was close security and intelligence coordination between Israel and the U.S. on everything happening in the region.

But he added: "With or without an agreement, and regardless of any external commitments, if Iran attempts to renew its nuclear programme or advance its ballistic missile industries, we will be there. We will take action, and we will strike." Trump and Netanyahu met on Tuesday in Washington, with an Israeli official saying they had explored all possible paths to curb Iran's nuclear programme, including diplomacy, economic pressure and force.

Tehran denies seeking a nuclear weapon.

Iran's acting defence minister, Brigadier General Majid Ebn Al-Reza, said Tehran viewed recent U.S. threats as "psychological and cognitive warfare" but was treating them seriously, adding that Iran would boost preparedness and deterrence rather than be caught off guard or remain passive. Press TV reported.

In his call with Trump, the Saudi crown prince stressed the "necessity of prioritising dialogue to de-escalate tensions" in West Asia, according to Saudi Arabia's state news agency.

A White House official told Reuters that the two had spoken

but did not provide details.

At a cabinet meeting on Friday, Trump said he held talks with U.S. negotiators, including his son-in-law Jared Kushner, special envoy Steve Witkoff, and Secretary of State Marco Rubio, could reach a deal with Iran. As an April ceasefire in the war unravelled last month, benchmark Brent crude futures jumped 24%, and analysts polled by Reuters expect prices to rise further this year.

Trump has argued that his stated goal of keeping Iran from gaining nuclear weapons justifies higher fuel costs in the near term, but the economic pain has put political pressure on him to find a way to end the war.

Adding to the energy industry's concerns, Iran's Houthis allies in Yemen in recent days began threatening the Bab el-Mandeb, the strait at the other end of the Red Sea from the Suez Canal, another export route for Saudi crude. The United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations said on Saturday it had received reports of two maritime incidents off Oman. In one, an unknown projectile struck a tanker, damaging the engine room. In the other, the master of a tanker reported seeing a large splash and an explosion close to the vessel, though no damage was reported.

Meanwhile, an Iranian lawmaker said on Sunday that mediators were seeking to revive a deal that briefly halted the war.

Hassan Ghasghavi, spokesman for Iran's national security commission, said in a video interview that "there is an effort underway to revive the 14-point Islamabad agreement, particularly by the mediators".

"They know that the main issue and, in fact, the key to the matter right now is the issue of the Strait of Hormuz, so yes, there is an exchange of views," he said.

The agreement, known as the Islamabad memorandum of understanding, was reached with the involvement of Iran's Gulf neighbour Qatar and Pakistan, with negotiating sessions held in Islamabad.

The deal included arrangements concerning the Strait of Hormuz and a resumption of diplomacy between Tehran and Washington for a broader deal.

In sub-Saharan Africa, climate change leading to slight increase in childhood malaria: Study

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NEW DELHI: Climate change has increased childhood malaria and could continue to do so in southern and East Africa where communities are less experienced at tackling the disease, while reducing the risk in today's hotspots as temperatures become too high for mosquitoes, according to a new study published in Nature.

The study—The past and future impact of climate change on childhood malaria in Africa—quantifies climate change's historical and future impact in sub-Saharan Africa's children, where most cases and deaths occur. It finds that climate change has slightly increased malaria overall.

Looking ahead, rising temperatures could increase the malaria risk in southern and East Africa while reducing it where it is most rampant today



Temperatures in today's hotspots are becoming too high for mosquitoes to survive.

as it becomes so hot that even mosquitoes struggle to survive.

"Climate change isn't just making malaria worse or better—it's moving it," said co-author Tamma Carleton, faculty head of Research for the Climate Impact Lab and an assistant professor at the University of California, Berkeley, in a statement. "Whether a place sees elevated malaria risks or reduced burdens under climate change depends on how hot it is today. We see relief in the current hot-

spots and new risk nearly everywhere else."

The study finds that climate change has slightly suppressed the spread of the disease in the warm, malaria hotspots of today, and will continue to as it gets too hot for the disease to flourish—posing other human health threats. This is especially the case in many large West African nations (Nigeria, Burkina Faso, Mali), where climate change will reduce cases by 5%. In extremely hot Sahelian countries (Niger, Gambia, Guinea-Bissau, Somalia) the disease may actually be fully eliminated.

The opposite is true for cooler regions where malaria isn't a significant problem today, such as southern Africa and high-elevation east Africa. In these areas, climate change is slowly making the temperature more suitable for mosquitoes to spread malaria, increasing cases by 5% in the Ethiopian highlands

(Kenya, Burundi) and by similarly large increases in Angola, Zambia, and northeast South Africa. By 2100, the risk could increase by 20 percent in regions like the Rift Valley and coastal southern Africa, creating new malaria challenges. But efforts to reduce emissions can change this trajectory. If the world is able to meet the 2°C warming threshold, this would avert 5 excess cases per 1,000 children in southern Africa and more in the east African highlands. It would also reduce the other widespread climate impacts that will be felt in central and western Africa as the planet continues to heat up. Further, while mitigation is crucial, so is adaptation. The southern and East African regions expected to be hit the hardest in the future are also regions that aren't accustomed to needing to fight the disease today.

{ DATIA }

Cong suspends ex-MLA ahead of bypoll results

Shruti Tomar

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BHOPAL: The All India Congress Committee (AICC) on Sunday night suspended former Datia MLA Rajendra Bharti from the party's primary membership, just a day before the results of the Datia Assembly by-election conducted on July 30.

The order, issued by AICC general secretary and Madhya Pradesh in-charge Harish Chaudhary, said, "with the approval of the president of the All India Congress Committee (AICC), Mallikarjun Kharge, Rajendra Bharti, former MLA from Datia, is hereby suspended from the primary membership of the Indian National Congress with immediate effect."

Bharti had defeated former home minister Narottam Mishra in the 2023 assembly election. However, in April this year, he was disqualified from the Legislative Assembly after a Delhi special court sentenced him to three years imprisonment in a fraud case.



Rajendra Bharti

The suspension followed allegations of anti-party activities during the Datia by-election campaign. Congress candidate Ghanashyam Singh submitted a written complaint to party president Mallikarjun Kharge and senior leaders, accusing Bharti of colluding with BJP leaders and attempting to sabotage the party's prospects.

"Bharti was working in collusion with BJP leaders and had received funding from the BJP. An attempt was made to harm the Congress party by distributing money among voters through Bharti's supporters," Singh alleged.

Counting of votes for the Datia by-election is scheduled for August 3.

Raids on aides of absconding Bengal trader

KOLKATA: The Birbhum district police in Bengal on Sunday raided the homes and offices of several people associated with Md Nazibuddin alias Tulu Mondal, the absconding kingpin of an illegal stone quarry and sand business. Officials aware of the probe said the investigation focused on his modus operandi which deprived the state of revenue worth hundreds of crores during the Trinamool Congress regime. "Closure notices were sent to eight illegal stone quarries," an officer said.

13-year-old girl's body found near UP railway station

MERUT: A 13-year-old girl was found dead under mysterious circumstances near the Vair railway station under the jurisdiction of the Kadod police station in Bulandshahr on Saturday. Her family alleged that she was sexually assaulted before being murdered, officials said. According to police, the minor, a resident of Nihari village in the Chaulapur police station area, went missing on July 31 and her family had been searching for her since then. The girl's body was found on Saturday evening, police said.

Constable found dead in barracks room in Barabanki

BARABANKI, UP: A 30-year-old policeman was found dead inside his room in the barracks of the 10th Battalion PAC campus on Sunday, authorities said. Deepak Singh, the deceased, was a Provincial Armed Constabulary (PAC) constable from the 2021 batch. According to police, a colleague became suspicious after Singh did not open his room for a long time in the morning. When the door was forced open, he was found dead. The body was sent for post-mortem after a forensic team checked the room, police said.

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{ OUR TAKE }

Collegium for consistency

The collegium system needs uniform norms on disclosure and legitimate confidentiality

Justice Ujjal Bhuyan's remarks questioning the Supreme Court collegium's recent retreat from recording reasons for judicial appointments have revived an uncomfortable but necessary debate. Nearly a decade after the collegium began publishing its resolutions in the interests of transparency, the institution appears to have made a U-turn, with recent recommendations once again reduced to bare announcements. The concern is not merely about disclosure; it is about consistency.

The collegium has always struggled to balance two competing values. Greater transparency enhances public confidence and allows scrutiny of whether appointments are based on objective criteria. At the same time, disclosure can unfairly damage the reputation of candidates, particularly sitting judges, whose names are in the zone of consideration but ultimately dropped or deferred. Publishing adverse comments or comparative assessments may cast lasting doubts over judges who continue to serve, even when no finding of impropriety exists. These concerns cannot be lightly dismissed. Yet the answer cannot be to swing between detailed disclosures under one collegium, comprising the Chief Justice of India and the four most senior judges, and complete opacity under another. Such fluctuations only reinforce the perception that transparency depends on the personal philosophy of the collegium of the day rather than on an institutional commitment. The Supreme Court itself, while striking down the National Judicial Appointments Commission in 2015, acknowledged the collegium's shortcomings in transparency and accountability and accepted the need for reform.

What is missing is a settled, principled framework. The collegium should evolve uniform norms specifying what must invariably be disclosed, what may legitimately remain confidential, and how reasons are to be recorded. The objective need not be publication of every internal discussion or dissent. It may well suffice to place in the public domain the broad criteria that informed a recommendation while protecting confidential material that could unjustifiably smear unsuccessful candidates.

Equally important is the process through which such norms are framed. Questions affecting the institutional credibility of judicial appointments should not depend on the views of the five-member collegium alone. They merit deliberation by the full court so that the Supreme Court speaks with one institutional voice. A framework endorsed collectively would ensure continuity across successive collegiums and prevent repeated reversals in policy.

The debate, therefore, is not one of transparency versus confidentiality. It is about replacing ad hoc discretion with predictable institutional standards. For an institution whose legitimacy rests on reasoned decision-making, consistency in its own appointment process is indispensable.

Looking for offshore oil to beef up supply

The Indian economy has done better than what most people expected in the wake of the oil shock from the ongoing Iran war. However, the roots of this resilience lie in the country's fiscal prowess, which allowed it to procure supplies at higher prices. This, while welcome, cannot be a strategy. India must reduce its energy import dependence on a long-term basis. Renewables will be an integral part of the plan, but it must also include securing fossil fuel supplies.

It is in this regard that the Cabinet decision to sanction \$84,000 crore for offshore oil and gas exploration over the next five years is welcome. The decision aims to boost India's domestic oil and gas offshore production by working on all levers: collect high quality seismic data, subsidise exploration activities and expand the industrial infrastructure to increase petroleum processing. The decision should be seen as one of the pillars to secure India's energy requirements. Exploration, even when successful, does not always translate into commercially viable scaling of operations. Also, it is unlikely that India's oil and gas production will ever have a share to reckon with in the country's overall energy needs.

So, energy security must work on other fronts too, including building large strategic reserves and technology to substitute between imported and domestically available fossil fuels (coal-based fertiliser production, for instance). The announcement of the Samudra Manthan project to aggressively pursue offshore oil and gas production should, hopefully, be the first of policy measures to boost energy security.

Data centres must pay their true costs

A bargain that subsidises electricity and scarce water, and absorbs the heat with no guarantees on enduring AI capability is not development

After New York's recent moratorium on large artificial intelligence (AI) data centres, American senator Kirsten Gillibrand issued a statement saying, "New Yorkers aren't convinced these massive facilities benefit them. Before we move forward, our communities need ironclad guarantees that their energy bills won't spike, their water will be protected, and their air will remain clean."

Do Indians deserve similar guarantees? Around the world, protests are erupting against AI and its data centres. Young people feel especially disadvantaged: looking at the layoffs and rapid hiring across white-collar industries, it's hard not to sympathise. Setting aside questions about the future of humanity, AI's feet of clay — its data centres — exact a tangible, if more mundane, cost across electricity, heat and water. Against this backdrop, the key question for India is not whether it gets for doing so.

Let's start with power. A 100MW site can draw more than two million

units a day. The International Energy Agency puts data-centre electricity consumption at 415 TWh in 2024 — enough to meet the annual needs of 353 million Indian households. In India alone, one projection sees data centre demand climbing from 10 TWh in 2025 to 191 TWh by 2040. Remember, this is near-constant loading, with periodic spikes that the grid must cope with. Hyperscalers report buying vast quantities of renewables, but that does not give the full picture: Wind is seasonal and the sun sets. Something must do the balancing, and someone must pay for it. As states dangle incentives for data centres, the factories in other sectors already employing millions may fairly ask: Why them, not us?

What water is provided, predictably, does not even appear in the listed benefits. Depending on the cooling system deployed and the local climate, a 100MW centre can consume almost no onsite water — or more than two million litres a day. Globally, the electricity and cooling needs of data centres had an estimated water footprint of some 4.5 trillion litres in 2025.

India's centres will cluster where the undersea cables terminate: mainly Mumbai and Chennai. Neither city is known for water resilience. Where will this water come from? Heat, spoken about the least, may matter the most. Almost all the electricity a server draws becomes heat,

which must be pushed out.

A recent preprint of a research study tracking two decades of temperatures across thousands of data centres, found temperatures in the vicinity of a data centre rose by about 2°C once it began operating. Temperatures stayed about 1°C higher up to 4.5km away and remained detectably higher at 10km — potentially exposing over 340 million people globally to the added heat.

In India's sweltering cities, that deserves far more attention than it is getting. And what is India actually getting?

"Jobs" is often the first response. True, construction brings hundreds, perhaps thousands, of jobs briefly, but most of those flow to migrants rather than the locals: once built, a 100MW centre may employ just 30 to 60 people on-site. Then, is India making the chips, servers, storage and memory, or building the AI models — or merely bolting together the racks and servers?

Are we the librarian backing up the glory of books other people wrote? India should not content itself with data centres with owning the AI economy. The former is subsidised real estate; the latter represents geostrategic power.

Back to those costs. The hyperscal-



Midula Ramesh



An industry that treats innovation as both virtue and God should not need cheap water, unpriced heat and unquestioned grid support.

ers are socialising a private cost — your prompt is cheap because someone else pays for the water and power. In America, where both are priced, a \$30 water bill can become \$250, sparking protests. In India, unpriced water sits in invisible aquifers; no one knows how much is drawn until they run dry.

The irony is that the innovation to mitigate some part of the data centres' environmental impact already exists. Renewable energy and storage have made great strides in the last decade. Water efficiency has improved as centres adopt closed-loop cooling and dispense with cooling towers; what little water they need, can be drawn from treated sewage.

Heat can be tamed too. In Denmark, Meta's wind-powered centre pipes its waste heat into the city's district-heating network. In India, waste heat emerges at 25-40°C, which a heat pump can lift it to 90-120°C. But without a nearby industrial user or a centralised grid, what becomes of it?

Subsidies and opacity blunt the need to innovate while transpar-

ency and constraints supply it. The alternative is not to turn away data centres but to make them earn their welcome.

Singapore's PUB helped unleash water innovation. Indian cities could do the same: Roll out the welcome mat for data centres on the condition that they transparently disclose and pay a fair price for the resources they consume, even fund a hub for cooling, heat recovery, water reuse, and grid management.

An industry that treats innovation as both virtue and God should not need cheap water, unpriced heat and unquestioned grid support. A bargain that subsidises electricity and scarce water, and absorbs the heat with no guarantees on enduring AI capability beyond data centres is not development. It is subsidising somebody else's intelligence.

Midula Ramesh is a climate-tech investor and author of *The Climate Solution and Watershed*. The views expressed are personal.

{ GRAND STRATEGY }

Happymon Jacob



Simultaneous balancing & engagement with China

China-India relations appear to be on the mend. Take a look at the last ten days of July. On July 22, external affairs minister S Jaishankar met his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi in Manila, on the margins of the East Asia Summit. Five days later, foreign secretary Vikram Misri was in Beijing, meeting vice-minister Hua Chunying, where both sides said the customary things about peace and tranquillity along the border. On July 30, our Mandarin-speaking ambassador in Beijing called on a Chinese vice-minister to discuss trade and market access, with Indian pharmaceuticals reportedly on the table. That is a lot in 10 days for two countries that are known to move slowly. Are we warming up to the Chinese too fast? Have we forgotten the winter of Galwan? There are two schools of thought in New Delhi.

One says, in criticism of course, that India is "drifting" fast into accommodation with China; that Galwan has been written off and that we are trading our way back into a dependence vis-à-vis China. The second set of arguments holds that Quid is ending, the rupture with the US is permanent, our Indo-Pacific commitments were always thinner than we admitted, and so the reset with China is the real story. Both sides assume that India must eventually settle into one clear posture: Balance China or trade with China. Both have been predicting such a clear decision, one way or another, for two years. But a closer look would suggest that the policy has been more complicated and, I think, in the right direction. Mostly.

I think there is a vocabulary problem in our assessment of our relationship with China. Multi-alignment, currently in fashion in New Delhi, describes a choice among partners, while strategic autonomy, also in fashion, describes freedom from other countries' choices. But neither of them describes a single relationship that runs in two opposite directions at the same time. Multi-alignment describes India's behaviour across its partnerships, but says nothing about what happens where a single country is a partner and adversary at the same time. In my upcoming book (*India After Normalcy*), I call that political simultaneity. Hypocrisy is when you claim to take a position, but actually have more than one position; simultaneity is when you openly take two positions and face the consequences.

It is possible for a country to take two competing positions at the same time, both incurring costs in different ways. China is perhaps the best case in the Indian context, because the balancing and the engagement of China is done by the same government since China is a security challenge, a trade partner and a next-door neighbour, and a lot more, all at once.

India's ongoing balancing of China is taking place in Ladakh, where roads, bridges, tunnels and logistics hubs have gone up, the Shyok Tunnel among them, with the Aruna-

chal Frontier Highway and the Nyoma airfield below it. None of it has been passed, or slowed, for or because of the reset, even if I personally think we have to do it more of balancing.

And the (re)engagement of China is taking place in the FDI regime. In March this year, the Union Cabinet announced Press Note 3, notified as Press Note 2 of the 2026 series and operationalised from the first of May. Investors carrying up to 10% of Chinese beneficial ownership may now use the automatic route, and proposals in capital goods, electronic components, polysilicon, and ingot-wafer manufacturing are to be cleared in 60 days, so long as Indian residents keep majority ownership and control. Direct Chinese investment still needs prior approval.

So, the larger question is whether the diplomatic activity witnessed in July, the activity before that, and the activity that is likely to follow means that New Delhi is finally giving up on balancing China? I hope not. It doesn't need to. Because New Delhi can balance and engage Beijing at the same time. The national security pundits who argue that China must be balanced are right; so is Indian industry that urges New Delhi to continue to do so. There is no contradiction.

In fact, New Delhi is not the only capital that does it. US secretary of state Marco Rubio came to the Quad ministerial meet in Delhi on May 26; 10 days after his President had made a warm State visit to Beijing, almost looking for a G2 with Beijing even though he got nothing in return. Washington works with China using the same two commitments, of balancing and engaging, and calls it statecraft. When we do it, we are accused of "drifting" one way or another.

But why does simultaneity with China matter? Here's why. China holds our territory and is undoubtedly India's primary challenge; but it also supplies a great deal of our manufacturing, electronic components, and pharmaceuticals. Cut the economic link with China, and our economy is bound to slow down. India cannot afford that. But if we accept the territorial aggression and nibbling, we end up giving up the deterrence we have spent six years and a lot of money putting back together. This is the predicament of a country large enough to have serious interests on both sides of the balance sheet. Great powers can, perhaps, afford clean choices because they can make up the loss elsewhere. We cannot; not yet.

So, India should balance with China and trade with China for as long as both can be done without sacrificing the other. The failure would be having to make that choice in the middle of a crisis, having never thought about it before and planned for it.

Happymon Jacob is founder and director, Council for Strategic and Defense Research, and editor, INDIA'S WORLD magazine. The views expressed are personal.

{ DONALD TRUMP } PRESIDENT, US

I have agreed, for the future benefit of the world ... to cancel the attack (on Iran), subject to being able to rapidly make a deal

Post on his Truth Social platform



{ STRAIGHTFORWARD }

Shashi Shekhar



Ending digital addiction to safeguard children's future

It's a slightly odd story. A 16-year-old boy was sitting in a police station in Uttar Pradesh. He had been detained for threatening to kill Prime Minister Narendra Modi, chief minister Yogi Adityanath and then Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar. The boy, from a rural background, wanted overnight fame and hence resorted to the online stunt. As if involved VIPs, the police zeroed in on him in no time. Later, the court took a lenient view considering his age and granted him bail. But this is no isolated case. There are thousands of such incidents where children or young adults perform such acts, compelled by their online addiction.

Online addiction has started affecting children in many adverse ways. The Academy of Medical Royal Colleges (AMRC) has categorised online addiction as a public health emergency. AMRC rates the addiction on a par with smoking.

The doctors participating in the survey confirmed that they receive at least one young patient every day who has been suffering mental or physical ailments due to excessive online engagement. The doctors warned that tech companies design their apps in a manner that turns people into addicts. We are well aware of online criticism, violent outbursts and other problems that children are addicted to.

It's no surprise that on June 15, the UK banned all forms of social media for children below 16 years of age.

Even the Norwegian government is going to take revolutionary new steps from August 1. Norway was the first country in the world to digitalise even the primary classes. The government of Norway and the country's society are now reversing the initiative. Norwegian education minister Mari Knaus Nordtun says that excessive use of screens in the school is affecting the core cognitive abilities of children. It's adversely impacting their physical and mental health. As a result many children are turning to cyber bullying. The Norwegian government is terming the initiative as "back to basics".

The government in Oslo decided a budget of millions of kroner two years ago to bring back textbooks in classrooms. The results are visible. From August 1, the use of screens for students of class 1 to 8 was completely stopped. A zero-screen law is already in place for children under two years of age. The government has tripled the grant for school libraries. This move will definitely be

a milestone in preserving human mind and cognition.

China too has restricted screen time for children below eight to 40 minutes in 24 hours. At 10 in the night, "internet curfew" is imposed which lasts till six in the morning. Beijing has restricted all those services that can make children AI addicts.

Even South Korean classrooms became out of bounds for mobile phones last month. The government has also established internet rescue schools. Here minors are kept in the lap of nature without any electronic gadget so they can revert to their natural human self.

Similarly, Australia has completely banned social media for children below 16 years of age, with hefty fines for companies found breaking the law. France is planning similar curbs. The head of the EU has urged European nations to make laws that decide the age at which children can access social media and also detox from algorithm-driven addiction.

Where does India stand on such an important issue? We have put some curbs under Online Gaming Regulations Act 2025 but we still have a long way to go.

The academic world is dealing with another issue — how can a golden mean be achieved in the era of AI? PISA (International Student Assessment Programme) and OECD (Organisation of Economically Developed Nations) studies enlighten us about the issue. They say that the AI tools are indeed a force multiplier for increasing human productivity but people will have to make a distinction between addiction and use.

Researchers found that when students with digital addiction restricted use of devices to three out of 24 hours, their results were way better. However, digital addicts whose screen time was not restricted failed maths tests despite access to their digital equipment. Close to 50% of students were found distracted by the laptops and smartphones of the others; 45% of students using smartphones for three to seven hours become fidgety if they lose access to it. The verdict is clear: Smartphones and laptops don't make students sharp. They need to develop discipline and focus. The beautiful balance between the power of AI and human wisdom is the only way to create a meaningful world.

Shashi Shekhar is editor-in-chief, *Hindustan*. The views expressed are personal.

Iran's leaders united on war but divided on goals

Associated Press
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CAIRO: With escalating attacks against US bases and its allies over the past week, Iran's leaders are showing considerable unity over their war strategy; hanging tough, determined to show Iran can endure more than America and its allies can.



Israeli battle tanks in a village in southern Lebanon on Sunday. **AP**

But within the leadership, there are sharp differences over what the endgame should be. On one side, the ultra-hardliners who oppose any negotiations with the US are pressing for total victory in the war. Known as the "Paydari" movement – Persian for "stability" – they are hard-core ideologues who want to enforce the Islamic Republic's control over society.

On the other, those who support President Masoud Pezeshkian and powerful parliament speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf – who doubles as Iran's chief negotiator – see military pressure as a way to win a negotiated deal with the US. This camp is also spurred by concern over the economic toll on Iran and the need to adapt to social change in the country.

"Negotiation is a political tool and a complement to military action to force the enemy to a point of compulsion and extract real concessions," an adviser to Qalibaf, Mahdi Mohammadi, said on Telegram.

The unusually open rivalry within the theocracy's leadership points to a struggle for control over Iran's postwar future. A huge question mark is where the new supreme leader, Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, stands. Khamenei remains in hiding, and both sides have claimed his support.

In a boost for Qalibaf and Pezeshkian, the ceasefire deal reached with the US in April received strong backing in Iran's top leadership body, the Supreme National Security Council. Twelve of its 13 members

approved it, including senior figures in the Revolutionary Guard and the military.

The lone vote against the deal is widely believed to have come from Saeed Jalili, the most prominent figure in the Paydari movement. But with no benefits from the deal, "there's no serious division" in the leadership over how to respond, said Ali Vaez, Iran project director at the International Crisis Group.

They believe Donald Trump "only understands the language of force, and therefore, they would have to gain the upper hand in order to compel him to deliver," Vaez said. The ultra-hardliners have used nightly rallies and their control of state television, known by the acronym IRIB, to drum up opposition to negotiations.

At rallies and on TV, speakers have portrayed Iran as headed for total victory and denounced those who compromise with the Islamic Republic's archenemy, the United States.

State television cut off a June 30 live broadcast with Qalibaf as he discussed negotiations with the US. Earlier this month, it cut off broadcasting a speech by Pezeshkian to businessmen seconds after he said that the elder Khamenei had given permission for renewed US talks before his

death. Pezeshkian and his camp have pushed back, portraying IRIB as dividing the country at the time of war. The president accused the broadcaster of making it like "the military are on one side, and the government is on another side."

Last month, the president's media office condemned state television for what it described as "censoring" the president and other government heads, signaling an open rift.

The hard-liners have sought to press their influence in other ways. In past weeks, authorities shut down cafes in central Tehran that were popular with residents during the ceasefire. Videos on Iranian social media showed many women at the cafes flouting mandatory veiling laws, and crowds mixing freely.

The closures were brief but signalled that "religious extremist parties" were showing their influence, said Mohammad Ali Abtahi, a reformist cleric and an aide to former President Mohammad Khatami, who is still widely considered to be the leader of Iran's reformist groups.

The more pragmatic camp argues that maintaining unity during the war requires addressing the public's unhappiness over the economy as well as political and social repression.

U.S. GENERAL SAYS HE LACKS FORCES TO PROTECT ISRAEL FROM IRAN ATTACK
WASHINGTON: A top American military commander stationed in Europe has cautioned the Pentagon that the United States lacks adequate naval assets to continue intercepting Iranian ballistic missile strikes on Israel. The development was reported by The Washington Post, which noted that the chief of US European Command, General Alexis Grynkeiwich, informed Pentagon officials that without the deployment of another US Navy destroyer to the region, European Command would eventually be forced to decide between protecting US interests and sustaining defense operations for Israel. **ANI**

ISRAEL SAYS IT HAS SERIOUS ISSUES WITH DEAL TO DISARM HAMAS
TEL AVIV: Israel has shared "serious security concerns" with the White House regarding the proposed disarmament deal with Hamas, an Israeli official said Sunday in what were some of the first public comments since Donald Trump announced the agreement.

Doron Spielman, spokesperson for the Israeli PM's office, said Israel's intelligence assessment is that Hamas remains committed to rebuilding its military rather than genuinely demilitarising. He said Israel would not withdraw from Gaza – where it controls more than 60% territory – before Hamas disarms. He said disarming means physically giving up the weapons, nothing less. **AP**

5 dead, 41 missing in ferry fire

Agencies
letters@hindustantimes.com
SURABAYA: An Indonesian ferry carrying 271 people caught fire in waters off the main island of Java on Sunday, leaving at least five people dead and dozens missing as rescuers and passing vessels evacuated hundreds from the burning ship, officials said, **AP** reported.

A total of 225 people on the vessel were rescued while 41 remain missing, **AFP** reported. The Mutiara Sentosa 2 ferry was traveling from Indonesia's second-largest city of Surabaya in East Java to the city of Makassar in South Sulawesi, with 232 passengers and 39 crew members, when the fire broke out between 6am and 7am in waters off Sumanep regency, according to Indonesia's National Search and Rescue Agency, or Basarnas.

The ferry operator, PT Atosim Lampung Pelayaran, reported the incident to the Surabaya search and rescue office about an hour later, Basarnas said in a statement.

It said the company received information from the ferry's captain that the vessel was on fire near the northern tip of Madura island, but contact was later lost. By 9.45am, authorities determined the ferry was about 19 nautical miles north of Buran Sapudi island after communicating with the nearby cargo vessel Meratus Project 3, which was unable to approach the burning vessel closely because it was carrying a flammable load.

Footage released by the National Search and Rescue Agency showed thick black smoke billowing from one side of the ferry and spreading across much of the ship.

In videos on social media, terrified passengers, mostly wearing life jackets, could be seen clustered on the deck.



Smoke rises from the passenger ship Mutiara Sentosa 2 off Madura island, East Java on Sunday. **AFP**

3 killed in shooting at US burger outlet

Associated Press
letters@hindustantimes.com
BOISE: Three people were killed and seven more were injured, some critically, in a shooting at an In-N-Out Burger restaurant in Idaho, United States on Saturday afternoon, a Twin Falls city spokesman said.

Police found the body of the suspected gunman in an area near the restaurant. Some of the people injured are in critical condition, police said.

Police were still trying to determine the shooter's identity and motive, officers said.

Eyewitnesses said they saw a person with an AR-style rifle emerge from the drive-thru. A man with a pistol started firing at the shooter. Then someone in an In-N-Out uniform dragged a person, also uniformed, bleeding from a gunshot wound in her chest across the parking lot.

Police said the shooter fired at least three or four rounds and it was not clear whether or not anyone in particular was targeted. Video taken by a driver from across the street captured a shooter, who appeared to be dressed in black, walking up to a white car carrying a long rifle, opening the driver-side door and popping the trunk.

The person then walked to the trunk and reached inside. At that point the driver who shot the video left quickly, fearing that the man might be getting more weapons.

The In-N-Out opened just about a week earlier, on July 24, as part of the company's recent expansion to Idaho.

Twin Falls, a city of about 56,000 people, is about 205km southeast of Boise and about 120 km north of the Nevada border.

Jailed Hindu rights leader granted bail by Bangladesh court

DHAKA: Bangladesh's high court on Sunday granted bail to jailed Hindu rights leader Chinmoy Krishna Das in two cases, his lawyer said. But the bail would not ensure his release from prison because he is accused in four other cases.

Das was arrested in 2024 on sedition charges. He was previously associated with ISKCON and is now a spokesman for Sammito Sanatan Jagaran Jote. **PTI**

Morocco honours Trump by naming highway after him
CAIRO: Moroccan King Mohammed VI said his decision to give US President Donald Trump's name to a \$1 billion highway that crosses into the disputed Western Sahara expresses his "deep appreciation" of the US leader. He said the 1,055km expressway between Tiznit and the Western Sahara city of Dakhla will be called the Donald J. Trump Highway. He hailed Trump's "historic recognition" of Moroccan rule of the resource-rich and disputed Western Sahara in 2020. **BLOOMBERG**

'Sopranos' actor Vincent Pastore dead at 80
NEW YORK: Vincent Pastore, a veteran actor who played mobsters and tough guys, and was best known for portraying Salvatore "Big Pussy" Bonpensiero on "The Sopranos," has died. He was 80. Pastore was found in his home on New York's City Island after not being heard from for a few days. **AP**

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Weightlifters Gyaneshwari Yadav (clockwise from top), Harjinder Kaur, Lovepreet Singh, Rishikanta Singh and Valluri Ajaya Babu upon their arrival at the Indira Gandhi International Airport in New Delhi on Sunday.



Weightlifting gold medalist Mirabai Chanu being welcomed on her arrival at Indira Gandhi International Airport after the Glasgow Commonwealth Games.

Despite missing sports, India hold top-five spot

With boxers sweeping up seven gold, India finished the Glasgow Games with 39 medals

Rutvik Mehta
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MUMBAI: The last time India finished outside the five best performing nations at the Commonwealth Games (CWG) was before the turn of the century, at the 1996 Kuala Lumpur edition.

India's fourth-place finish in the medals table of the 2026 Glasgow CWG, in that sense, may seem par for the course. But in a 10-sport edition that had no takers until a last-minute scramble and was heavily downsize with most of the country's traditionally strong sports axed, the Indian contingent in Glasgow still managed to stand its ground. And that India still managed to keep their place among the top five nations with 39 medals (13 gold, 17 silver, 9 bronze) is a creditable statement.

It's a statement that also augurs well for what's to come at the end of the next four-year cycle — the 2030 CWG in Ahmedabad where India will eye a bigger push on home turf. After the last home CWG in New Delhi in 2010, where the hosts scored the 100 mark, India's total medals hovered between 60 and 70 across the next three editions.

2022 Birmingham's tally was noteworthy given shooting, the biggest contributor to India in its CWG history, had been axed.



Gulveer Singh (in blue) during the men's 10,000m.

2026 Glasgow's tally is even more so, given sports that contributed to almost half of India's total count four years ago were not around. That included wrestling (12 medals), table tennis (7), badminton (6), squash (2), hockey (2) and cricket (1). The drop from Birmingham to Glasgow could have been steep. Instead, India held relatively firm — propelled by the medal rush in the final stretch and medals from para sports, particularly para athletics from an Indian lens, getting integrated to the overall volume.

That India held firm despite weightlifting somewhat losing its grip — one of the country's most productive CWG disciplines went from 10 medals and 3 gold in 2022 to 8 medals and 1 gold in 2026 — also shows the

degree to which other sports stepped up. Leading the way were boxing, athletics and, the surprise package of these Games, judo. Even with an asterisk of the level and competitiveness of the sport at the CWG, boxing delivered for India, and how. From three gold medals each in 2018 and 2022, boxers pooled in more than double of that (seven), and half of the contingent's overall gold count in Glasgow. The women grabbed more gold (8) than the men (5), and boxing where Indian women swept five of the seven titles on offer, was largely responsible for that.

The upcoming Asian Games, though, will be a clearer assessment ground of where the boxers are truly at, especially with

medalstally

COUNTRY	AUS	70	45	56	171
1	AUS	70	45	56	171
2	ENG	29	45	36	110
3	CAN	19	20	23	62
4	IND	13	17	9	39
5	SCO	13	9	17	39
6	NZL	10	14	12	36
7	NGR	10	7	7	24
8	JAM	10	4	5	19
9	WAL	9	10	12	31
10	MAL	8	3	5	16

the bigger picture of the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. Glasgow's Scotstoun Stadium saw the most number of Indians step on to the podium. India's track and field group doubled the medals from Birmingham (8) to Glasgow (16). Unlike Birmingham, though, this included para athletics, where Indians won six medals, and there significantly, all three gold.

A champion from among able-bodied athletes may not have come (there was one each in 2022, 2018 and 2014) but the double-digit medals reflect the continued growth of Indians in athletics, which still maintains some competitive quality at the CWG.

Gulveer Singh and Tejasswin Shankar epitomised that growth by taking Indian track and field to uncharted territory.

If Avinash Sable's 3,000m double in Glasgow set new ground for an Indian distance runner.

If Gulveer became the first Indian to win two athletics medals in a single CWG edition, Bir-

mingham high jump bronze medalist Tejasswin added another in a different discipline in Glasgow. Decathlons can be gruelling for athletes even at peak fitness, and here was Tejasswin with a flared up patellar tendonitis not just starting in it, completing it, but also claiming bronze. It was the first medal by an Indian in the event.

Yashvir Singh's bronze to go with the ever-bankable Neeraj Chopra's silver also showed the depth in Indian javelin, which had two from the country on the podium for the first time at the CWG.

And how incredible were those couple of gold medals from Indian judoka? Asmita Dey and Harsh Singh took Indian judo where it had never been before in these Games. It was an incredible show, even more so against the backdrop of the sport's administrative and doping issues back home. Judo was by far the most surprising storyline at this CWG.

The surprising storyline from the previous CWG, however, couldn't quite back it up. Lawn bowls accounted for two medals in 2022. With both those events trimmed from the programme and the conditions and format changed drastically and indoors, India couldn't repeat their Birmingham bowls bash. Glasgow, though, was no poorer. Condensed and compact it may have been, but it put on a fairly commendable show over 10 days. As did India in it, no matter what wasn't there.

What will be there in four years will be a home Commonwealth Games. Over to Ahmedabad, then.

Mirabai Chanu eyes Asiad high after Glasgow glitter

Shantanu Srivastava
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NEW DELHI: India's weightlifting contingent, led by its lone gold medalist Mirabai Chanu, returned from the Glasgow Commonwealth Games to a rousing welcome here on Sunday. Mobbed at the airport and at the hotel where the team will stay for two days, Mirabai dealt with the attention with her trademark grin.

"This medal means a lot to me. Coming from Manipur, I never thought I'll come this far. I followed in the footsteps of Kunjarani Devi who was an icon when I was growing up, and now when youngsters seek me out, it feels special," she said.

The Glasgow podium was a third straight CWG gold for the 2023 Tokyo Olympics silver medalist. Overall, it was her fourth CWG medal, and it completed a circle for it was in the 2014 Glasgow CWG that her international career took off, with a silver.

Then IS Mirabai has since won medals at every elite competition, including the Asian and World Championships. The only medal missing from her overflowing cabinet is the Asian Games. Mirabai, with coach Vijay Sharma, have already turned their attention to the Games, to be held in Japan from September 19 to October 4.

"It's the real deal, I'd say," said Sharma. "The Asian Games competition is as good as, if not tougher, as the Olympics or World Championships. That's why it's the most sought after medal for us."

"The preparation will begin as soon as we reach our training base (Madangar) in a couple of days. We barely have 50 days, which means we can't relax."

For Mirabai, the desire to beat the Chinese and North Korean lifters fuels her Asian ambitions. Since women's weightlifting was added in Asian Games at Beijing 1990, China has won six and North Korea the last two in the lightest category (48-59kg).



North Korea's Ri Song-gum, she will have to cut down at least 15kg to make the weight for the 49kg event. Things were tough in Glasgow where she took part in 48 kg. "It was brutal. It's not easy to cut weight beyond a point," she said. For two days leading up to her event, Chanu survived on one meal a day. "That's just one meal for two days. I would have cornflakes and eggs at breakfast and forget about eating the rest of the day. A day before the medal, I even cut down my water intake. You can understand how tough it is to train without food and water," she said.

Sharma agreed. "It was terrible for her. She'll have to do it all over again for Asiad."

Two days before her CWG event, Chanu weighed 50.100kg. She dropped 600gm the next day to reach 49.500kg, still 15kg heavier. Cutting down on food and water, Chanu stepped on the scale two hours before her lift to weigh 47.500kg. Sharma said: "You barely get time to eat after weigh-in. Take out 30 minutes for warm-up, and you have just about an hour to refuel. She usually has some banana or a small, boiled potato to get energy. You can't stuff yourself before lifting. It's an excruciating exercise."

Mirabai will stay hungry for now — for that missing Asian Games medal.

RESULTS (INDIANS ONLY)



Dev Kumar Meena

ATHLETICS
Mixed 4x400m relay final India finished 6th
Men's pole vault final Dev Kumar Meena finished 4th
Kuldeep Kumar finished 6th

SHOOTING
Men's 400m Points Race Qualifying Round Harshveer Singh Sekhon and Dinesh Kumar failed to qualify
Men's 1000m Time Trial Final Ronaldo Singh Laitonjam finished 20th
Women's 4-C5 1000m Time Trial Final Lisha Das finished last (6th)

JUDO
Women's -78kg, Round of 16 Ishroop Narang bt Nicole Wood (SCO) 162-051
Quarter-final: Ishroop Narang lost to Emma Reid (Eng) Ippon
Repechage: Ishroop Narang bt Georgika Moune (CMR) 101-251
Bronze playoff: Ishroop Narang lost to Coralie Godbout (CAN) 052-151
Men's -100kg, Round of 16 Arfar Singh lost to Aristos Michael (Cyp) Ippon
Men's -100kg, Round of 16 Yash Ghangas lost to Joshua Whitehouse (Wal) 1-052

Judoka Ishroop loses bronze medal playoff



India's Ishroop Narang (in white) competes against Canada's Coralie Godbout.

Agencies
sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

GLASGOW: Judoka Ishroop Narang gave her all in the bronze medal playoff but lost to Canadian Coralie Godbout by yuko as India's judo campaign ended at the Commonwealth Games without any medal on the concluding day.

The hopes to add one more medal in the Indian tally were riding on Ishroop after she jumped into medal contention following her tremendous win over Cameroon's stronger and taller Georgika Wesley Djengue Moune in the repechage round of women's -78 kg.

The 19-year-old won by yuko after her opponent scored two arios. However, an aggressive Godbout proved a tough nut to crack for Ishroop, who received two shidos in the regulation time and eventually lost in the golden score time.

Yash Ghangas and Arfar Singh, the other Indian judokas in the fray on the final day, faced

in the round of 16.

Judo consisted four medals, including two historic gold, one silver and a bronze. Earlier in the day, Ishroop lost to Ippon to England's Emma Reid in the quarterfinal. She recovered by scoring two yuko penalties while Emma secured two waza-ari scores during the four-minute contest to complete the victory.

The Indian pair registered a win by yuko in the golden score period against Nicole Wood of Scotland in the round of 16 match.

The match remained deadlocked at the end of regulation time, with both judokas picking up a shido each. Ishroop finally broke the stalemate one minute and 40 seconds into the golden score, scoring a decisive yuko to seal the contest after five minutes and 40 seconds.

In the men's section, Arfar Singh suffered a loss to Ippon to Cyprus' Aristos Michael in the -100kg round of 16 event.

Wales' Joshua Whitehouse in the final of 16.

Whitehouse secured the decisive yuko midway through the contest and held on to his advantage to win the bout.

Ghangas, who picked up two shido penalties during the four-minute contest, was unable to find a way back as his campaign ended in the opening round.

Yuko is awarded for a throw where the opponent lands on their side or near-side, or for a hold-down lasting 5 to 9 seconds.

Ippon is the highest score and means a full point that ends the match right away. Ippon is earned through a clean throw, a hold down, or a tap out.

Boxing: Big haul a stepping stone for tougher tests ahead

Seven of India's 13 gold at Glasgow came from boxing, but the success should be viewed through a realistic prism

Shantanu Srivastava
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NEW DELHI: Indian boxers capped their Glasgow Commonwealth Games campaign in style, winning seven gold and three silver medals on the penultimate day of competition. The gold rush sent India into top-five on the medals table, a no mean feat considering that most of country's stronger sports — wrestling, shooting and badminton — were not in the Games. India ended with 39 medals (13 gold, 17 silver, 9 bronze).

With seven of the country's 13 gold medals coming from the boxing ring, the magnitude of the haul can't be stated enough. India's gold count surpassed the previous best at CWC and went past England, who won six gold twice (London 1954, Gold Coast 2018), while Canada had matched that tally at Edinburgh 1986.

While the overall tally in boxing rose only marginally, from nine medals in 2018 to 10 in 2026, the number of gold went from three to seven. Celebrate we must, but sweeping success like this runs the risk of losing perspective. Indian boxers as well as the Boxing Federation of India (BFI) will do well to assess the success with a degree of pragmatism. The quality of boxers in the women's field was never going to test the Indians, although the men's side of the draw was far more competitive.

Indian returns shouldn't come as a total surprise to those following the sport. While women's box-



Gold medal winning boxers Sakshi Chaudhary (51kg), Jaismine Lamboria (57kg), Arundhati Choudhary (70kg), Preeti Pawar (54kg) and Priya Ghanghas (60kg). (Picture top right) Sachin Siwach (60kg) and Ankush Panghal (80kg).

ing in India is witnessing an unprecedented surge, the men's group is in transition. Only two Indian men — Amit Panghal and Nishant Dey — made the cut for the Paris Olympics while Nikhat Zareen (50kg), Preeti Pawar (54kg), Jaismine Lamboria (57kg), and Lovlina Borgohain (75kg) made the women's team in what turned out to be a medal-less run.

In 2025, at the World Boxing Championships in Liverpool, no Indian man could win a medal while Minakshi Hooda (48kg gold), Jaismine Lamboria (57kg gold), Nupur Sheoran (+80kg silver) and Pooja Rani (80kg bronze) pushed India to overall third in the tally, behind Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan. At the season-ending World Boxing Cup Final in Greater Noida late last year, Indian boxers swept 20 medals, including nine gold, in a severely depleted field and some questionable refereeing.

In Glasgow, the absence of central Asian countries as well as Japan and China gave India a decent shot at history. And credit to the boxers, they took it. Sakshi Chaudhary (51kg), Preeti Pawar (54kg), Jaismine Lamboria (57kg), Priya Ghanghas (60kg), Arundhati Choudhary (70kg), Sachin Siwach (60kg) and Ankush Panghal (80kg) ensured the national anthem barely stopped at the SEC Centre.

Olympic medalist Lovlina Borgohain (75kg), Jadumani Singh (55kg) and Narendra Brevail (+90kg) lost in the final to finish with silver medals. The toughest test will come at the Asian Games in Japan (Sept 10-Oct 4) where China, Uzbekistan, Japan and North Korea, among others, will be present. At the 2022 Asian Games in Hangzhou, the 13-member boxing team returned with one silver and three bronze.

BFI president Ajay Singh was honest in his assessment. "You

can't replicate this performance at the Asian Games. There's no question about that," he said in a virtual media interaction with the boxing squad. "For us, Asian Games is like the Olympics. The top-5 teams of the world — Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan and India — will be there. There will be China. This performance will not be replicated but we will still do well," Singh said.

Santiago Nieva, the women's team head coach, also sounded a note of caution. "We can't guarantee that we will win gold all the time but we are on the right track. As a group, we are quite realistic. We know how strong the field will be at the Asian Games. After that, there's the World Championships where Olympic quotas will be on offer. There will be an Asian qualifier later which will also feature a very strong field. We know there are tough tests ahead. The boxers are aware," Nieva said.



PTU/AP

"England are usually quite strong against us but this time we beat them in six out of eight bouts and we doubled them on the medal table. Couple of months back we were at the Asian Championships and won five gold medals," he added.

To be fair, not all bouts were one-sided either. Young Ankush Panghal (80kg) made a remarkable comeback after losing the opening round while Priya (60kg) needed to win her last round in all her three bouts. The men got some boost through Sachin and Ankush's wins. Jadumani, having stepped up to 55kg, was arguably the most entertaining Indian male boxer, while Narendra Brevail won a rare super heavyweight medal (silver) for India (+90kg).

Whether that translates into success against Asia's heavyweights will become clear within weeks in Japan.



Vansh Bedi of Central Delhi Kings in the DPL. DOCA

Vansh cameo helps Central beat Outer

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: Vansh Bedi produced a stunning cameo to power Central Delhi Kings to their second straight win in the Delhi Premier League 2026, sealing a thrilling four-wicket victory over Outer Delhi Warriors at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Sunday.

With 131 needed for victory, the Kings chased down the target in 9.5 overs, finishing on 133/6 to consolidate their place at the top of the table. The chase was built on quick-fire contributions throughout the order before Bedi applied the finishing touches with an unbeaten 47 of just 16 balls.

The left-arm keeper-batter smashed three fours and five sixes at a staggering strike rate of nearly 294, keeping his composure despite a flurry of wickets in the closing stages.

Central Delhi had made a flying start through captain Yash Dhill, who blasted 35 off 16. Jonty Sidhu

then maintained the momentum with a brisk 25 from 12 deliveries, laying the perfect platform for Bedi's match-winning assault.

Earlier, after being put into bat, Outer Delhi posted 130/5 in their 10 overs. Yash Sharma led the charge with a blistering 39 off 16 balls, while Mohit Panwar struck a vital 37 from 18. Aishwajit Saini chipped in with a rapid 31 off 15. Keshav Dabas was the pick of the Central Delhi bowlers with figures of 2/14, while Arun Pundir (1/13), Tejas Baroka (1/33) and Ganvish Khurana (1/20) claimed wickets to keep the Warriors in check.

For Outer Delhi Warriors, Pratham Saluja and Aman Chaudhary picked up two wickets each, but Bedi's late blitz ensured the Kings crossed the line with a ball to spare.

Brief scores: Outer Delhi 130/5 in 10 overs (Yash Sharma 39, Mohit Panwar 37, Keshav Dabas 2/14); Central Delhi 133/6 in 9.5 overs (Vansh Bedi 47, Yash Dhill 35, Aman Chaudhary 2/15). **CDK won by 4 wickets.**

Tanvi marks arrival with first Tour title

Sandip Sikdar

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NEW DELHI: Tanvi Sharma has announced her arrival. All the talk about the young shuttler's talent and skill was on display as she won her maiden BWF World Tour title at the \$250,000 Taipei Open on Sunday.

Just 17, Tanvi captured the title after delivering a masterclass against Vietnamese Nguyen Thuy Linh, beating the sixth seed 21-16, 21-16 in 36 minutes at the Taipei Arena. The shuttler from Punjab not also cemented her legacy as the youngest winner across any discipline in the tournament's 46-year history.

This is only the third time that the tournament has seen an Indian victory. Saina Nehwal won the women's singles in 2008 and Jwala Gutta and V Diju the mixed doubles a year later, during the Grand Prix Gold era.

Tanvi is the fourth Indian player (pair, after PV Sindhu (Japan Open), Devika Shag (Thailand Masters) and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy/Chirag Shetty (Singapore Open)) to win a BWF World Tour title this season.

Coming into the Sunday showdown, Tanvi held the psychological edge of a previous victory over Linh at the 2023 US Open. Despite the immense pressure of having to win a maiden title — she had lost her three previous finals in the World Junior Tour along with the World Junior Championships final last year — Tanvi stepped on the court with poise.

She immediately dictated the tempo in the opening game, surging to a 10-2 advantage. The experienced Vietnamese mounted a resurgence to narrow the deficit to two points (10-8), but Tanvi absorbed the pressure and maintained her lead to close out the first game.

The second game presented a



Tanvi Sharma in action at the Taipei Open. BADMINTON PHOTO

tougher test of her mental fortitude. Facing an early three-point deficit, Tanvi could have let her nerves get the best of her, but she engineered a remarkable turnaround. Relying on an aggressive, front-foot strategy, she relentlessly moved her opponent across the court with pinpoint cross-court striking and impeccable shuttle placement.

Refusing to let the sixth seed settle into a rhythm, Tanvi flipped the script to build a seven-point cushion at 15-8. She delivered the final blow — a spectacular cross-court drop that left her opponent struggling to reach the straight games coronation.

Despite dropping only one game throughout the week, Tanvi was humble at the media interaction. Admitting to battling nerves ahead of the biggest match of her young career, she explained her straightforward mental approach,

adding that she simply wanted to give her maximum effort, rely on her established game plan, and play without fear.

Tanvi expressed surprise at her remarkable run. "I'm really, very happy to win this title here," she beamed. "I didn't expect to win a title, but yeah, I just thought I'll give my best over here. I was going step by step, match by match."

Acknowledging the physical toll grinding it out across five high-intensity matches over the week takes, she put down her excellent show to focus and consistency. With her maiden World Tour crown solidly in her grasp, Tanvi is aware of the steep climb ahead. Recognising the punishing nature of the tour, she admitted she had to work hard to challenge the sport's elite at Super 500 and 750 events.

She next plays the Korea Masters from Tuesday.

Ankur, Yashaswini bag men's, women's titles

NEW DELHI:

Ankur Bhattacharjee and Yashaswini Chorpade clinched the men's and women's singles titles with contrasting wins at the Commonwealth TT Championships. Bhattacharjee beat Payas Jain 4-3. In the women's final, Chorpade delivered a commanding performance to defeat Sreeja Akula 4-1.

Eala stuns Osaka in Washington semis

WASHINGTON:

Alexandra Eala stunned former world number one Naomi Osaka 6-4, 6-2 to reach the women's final of the WTA and ATP Washington Open, where she will face third-ranked Jessica Pegula. The 21-year-old Philippines player delivered an impressive victory over the four-time Grand Slam winner to reach her second WTA final.

Lovlina hurt by missing NE on map

NEW DELHI:

Boxer Lovlina Borgohain said she felt hurt after noticing that India's Northeast was missing from a map printed on the napkins and displayed outside a popular Indian restaurant in Glasgow. The owners acknowledged the mistake and promised to rectify it. The incident occurred when the boxing contingent visited the restaurant for dinner.

Sharma hits blistering 233 in inter-district

NEW DELHI:

Abhishek Sharma smashed 233 from 91 deliveries in the Punjab State Inter-District one-dayers. Playing for Amritsar against Taran Taran, Abhishek's knock was studded with 14 fours and 25 sixes as it piled up 533 in 50 overs. In the chase, Taran Taran managed 313/8 led by a century from Arshdeep Singh but fell short by 220 runs.

Messi returns as Inter Miami draw 2-2

MIAMI:

Lionel Messi returned to MLS, coming on in the 53rd minute as his Inter Miami side drew 2-2 with Columbus Crew. Luis Suarez scored to put Miami 1-0 up in the 16th minute. Casemiro scored his own goal in the 34th minute which drew Columbus level at 1-1. Noah Allen helped Miami to a 2-1 lead which Brais Mendez neutralised.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of



THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

Sunday Hindustan Times
JANUARY 22, 2023

HT TWTW
THE WEEK THAT WAS

Take a cue from the clues

Authors who are not authors, leaders who no longer lead, a beauty queen walks her last walk, and cranks appear in a film about village. More happened this week. Take the quiz to find out.

Natasha Rego

Amman Rehli (right) is the author of the children's book *After and Sparkle (above)*. Who actually wrote and illustrated it?

Amman Rehli is not an author or illustrator, but he "wrote" *After and Sparkle*, a children's book which has sold over 800 copies since it was launched by Naveen at the UK General Assembly at three months last week, she said. "You can be your own kind of leader — one who knows when it's time to go." What?

She's a legend! Maman and was briefly a B.M. Her daughter Clara (left) is a filmmaker. Her daughter Naveen attended the UK General Assembly at three months last week, she said. "You can be your own kind of leader — one who knows when it's time to go." What?

The *Blue Crane* blocked the *Suez Canal* in 2021. Now the world's largest container ship is approaching India. What's the connection?

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